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EDITOR'S NOTE

"This, fundamentally, is why we cannot stay away from history: it offers the only extensive evidential base for the contemplation and analysis of how societies function."

– Dr Peter N. Stearns

As editors for Milton's history publication and as students who have devoted a significant chunk of our time at school to the study of the past, we often wonder to ourselves, "Why study history?" Historical knowledge does not help us with everyday competencies, it rarely lends itself to easy employment, and even its ability to convince someone of an argument dwindles by the day as people grow less and less comfortable with listening to those they disagree with. Moreover, contrived arguments like that we should learn history to prevent its tragedies from repeating themselves are abstract and unconvincing.

As we learned more about history, however, the answer became more clear: history helps us better understand the profound whys of the world- why political and economic systems work the way they do, why people feel certain ways, why people disagree with each other, and so on. The world is nothing more than the sum of all human decisions, and the study of history examines the "code" that underlies all these decisions. In understanding this "code", we better understand not only ourselves and the world but also how to shape it. This knowledge helps us critically in every area of our lives, from civic participation to discussions with friends to deciding what we find meaningful enough to do for a living. Knowing more makes us much more likely to make better decisions. This is why we must study history.

If history helps us understand why people do things, then what answers has it provided? We hope that this issue of Prism Youth Journal provides a glimpse into some of the insights Milton students have managed to glean from their deep-dives into history; no answer is the whole picture, but all of them bring us one step closer to understanding humanity itself. Rhys Adams '26's paper on the institutional role of the military in hindering Syrian democratization reveals the centrality of bureaucratic power in sustaining the collective behavior of violence. Meanwhile, Molly O'Brien '26's paper on Panda Diplomacy interestingly advocates for the underrated importance of our tendency to find things cute in shaping global politics. Papers from eight other Milton students each paint their own

unique stories filled with nuances and revelations.

We hope you read this issue and come away having learned something about history, the world, or yourself. More importantly, though, we urge you to do something meaningful with what you learned. For our money, history teaches two skills: the skill of humbly learning something new and the skill of standing up for what we believe in. The fact that you are reading this publication indicates that you need little help with the former. As for the latter, we urge you to take what you have gained and seriously contemplate how it should add nuance to your worldview and to stand by those views in every decision you make. History is not a natural phenomenon—it demands each of us to make decisions to shape it to our will. We hope you learn some history and then write more yourself. Anything less is to waste your talent as a historian.

Yours sincerely,

The Editors-In-Chiefs

Molly and HT

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THE RELATIVE MAGNITUDE AND ENDURANCE OF AMERICAN LIBERTY

HENRY MANNINO

Milton Academy '26

An Introduction

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In the time after the Great War, many European countries began to shift to be more nationalistic, imperial, and liberal ideals began to offshoot from the norm. First, it is important to define liberalism, as it can be viewed differently in different societies. Liberal governments are those who promote and secure individual liberties, at a federal level. This definition does not include those who do suspend those individual liberties to idealistically promise them at a later date, or who claim to support liberality, then govern to the contrary. Both the German Weimar Republic, established by the Liberal Socialist Democratic Party (SPD), and the Russian Revolution's founding ideas were those of liberalism; however, these ideals did not last long, and were eventually replaced with Authoritarian limitation on individual liberty, and the promise of a future utopia at the expense of that very free individualism. Similarly, the United States was founded on the ideals of liberty, though unlike their Germanic and Russian counterparts, these ideals proved to be durable, and did not ever decimate, or even -many would argue- slightly dilute. This seems to be linked to the very definition of liberalism previously mentioned, which is the focus on individualism. American society is founded on ideas of individualist freedom, whereas European Liberalism was diluted by collectivism, and thereby proved to be more flexible and malleable. Furthermore, with such uncertain safety and constant war, a focus on individualism threatened to lead to capitulation for European states, and so was incredibly unsavory compared to the comparatively strong collectivism.

The Ever Durable American Individualist Liberalism

In the Declaration of Independence, Thomas Jefferson outlined what ideas Americans had that were mutually exclusive with British rule -and thereby required independence from Britain. The primary idea of the American hypothesis "...that all men are created equal, that they are endowed, by their Creator, with certain unalienable rights, that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness" (Jefferson) was written to introduce the document. These ideas are not new, they are almost exactly re-penned from those described in John Locke's Second Treatise on Government; however, they had never been applied to government, especially at their extreme. Through this infamous line, the idea of individualism is cemented: securing one the inalienable right to a free and liberal life, in which they can pursue their own individual interests without government interference. This last piece is key to what separates American Liberalism from European Liberalism. In America, as opposed to other nations' promotion of behavior which inherently benefits society, one can engage in behavior regardless of its societal utility. The only caveat to one's pursuit of happiness is when it inhibits another's. The idea of this limit is well illustrated in a classic American adage often attributed to a Judge "Your liberty to swing your fist ends just where my nose begins." (Unattributed). The speaker of this quote is hypothesized to range from important author on liberty John Stuart Mills, Supreme Court Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes, and even President Abraham Lincoln; however, attribution of this quote is not really important as it has cemented itself as legal precedent in the United States independent of the identity of the quoted. The meaning of the Judges' words illustrates that one has unregulated liberty, up until the point at which it is harmful to another. While this may at first seem like a restriction on individualism, as it restricts harmful action, it can actually viewed as a further benefactor of liberal individualism. The adverse of the adage is to say that the Judge's pursuit of happiness cannot be inhibited by an aggressor using their individual desire to restrict his liberty. In viewing the quote this way, by inhibiting the aggressor's right to harm The Judge, The Judge's individual liberty is protected from outside influences and regulations. Furthermore, the aggressor has unrestricted individual freedom and autonomy to move his fist, up until the point at which it hits the Judges nose. Therein, so long as the Judge's liberty is not decimated or diminished, the aggressor has full liberty over their fist. The extreme at which individual liberty is emphasized in the United States is truly unrivaled, original, and it directly secures American Liberalism to not face rivals. Any threat to individual liberalism -if the adage holds true, and the pursuit of happiness is absolute and adequately protected- is impossible: threatening liberalism

directly rivals the founding principles of the state, and is essentially impossible without full government capitulation and re-establishment due to the safety nets present in the government. Furthermore, the fault which European Liberal Governments fall to, that of extreme collective liberalism, cannot exist. One cannot both pursue their own happiness and be expected to sacrifice their individualism to a collective goal.

American Individualism's Durability In Wartime and in Crisis

6 Having this strong individual liberty may seem to conflict with the need for a strong wartime presence and life in war and or crisis. It does definitely affect life in war and crisis, though, historically, solutions have been found for the two to coexist. In a crisis, individualism is upheld adequately on average by the government. Coming out of the Depression, and into wartime, President Franklin Delano Roosevelt established the New Deal. The New Deal set out primarily to fix, what FDR described in his Fireside Chat of July 24th, 1933 as the "...the part of the problem that concerned the credit of the individual citizens themselves," the lack of money in American pockets due to the Great Depression, an incredibly serious crisis. The Depression directly infringed on American Individualism as people were forced into dependence on employers for money, and thereby became slaves to economic opportunity. FDR's solution was the New Deal. While it is criticized by many, and most definitely eerily slips down the slope of Government overreach, it had the noble goal of helping American individual pursuits. Through increasing welfare programs, Americans who faced any sort of crisis -whether it be financial, military, or health-based- would have a fall safe, and thereby not lose their individualism to poverty-based dependence. This deal ended up successfully pulling Americans out of the depression, thereby allowing them to continue to execute their individualist dreams. The one major caveat to government protection of American Individualism is found in the wartime draft. By forcing conscription into military battle, one's life and individual liberty is directly infringed on. FDR did tend to be criticized for his infringements on individual liberty; however, he did hope to restore individualism to the citizens -that part is key- after the war. In a statement on reducing the draft conscription minimum age, FDR stated he was working on a plan "...for the taking of steps to enable the young men whose education has been interrupted to resume their schooling and afford equal opportunity for the training and education of other young men of ability after their service in the armed forces has come to an end." (Statement on Signing the Bill Reducing the Draft Age). This may seem like European Collectivist dreams, and while it is concerningly similar, it has one major distinction; the Europeans do not promise

a return to liberalism for the contemporary individual, like FDR argues, rather, they promise utopia for the future generations, at the expense of the current individual. In Europe, however, very little welfare would be assigned to the current individual, as he is simply a cog in the machine.

European Collectivism, as it was adopted by Germany

The idea of liberalism, as it is viewed in America, may seem appealing; however, across Europe, the idea was contaminated by Collectivism. In Weimar Germany, individualism was in fact held as a fundamental right; however, it could be stripped if necessary by the government. The Weimar Constitution states in Article 114 that "Personal liberty is inviolable. Curtailment or deprivation of personal liberty by a public authority is permissible only by authority of law." (Weimar Constitution) Therein is the major threat to individualism, in states of emergencies, it can be violated; though it is not concretely secured, nor is it held sacred, the Third Reich did in fact begin with individual liberty protected. However, within a month of Adolf Hitler's appointment as Chancellor, this protection was stripped -and was able to be striped due to the article's weak language After the arson of the German Parliamentary Building, Nazi leaders pushed for The Decree of the Reich President for the Protection of the People and the State, popularly known as The Reichstag Fire Decree. Ultimately, the Nazis utilized the fire to convince President von Hindenburg to approve drastic limitations on liberty, as the fire promoted a crisis to the Government, and thereby a threat to the German people as a whole -as a collective. The opening line of the document states that "[many articles, including article] 114... of the Constitution of the German Reich [is] suspended until further notice. Therefore, restrictions on personal liberty, on the right of free expression of opinion, including freedom of the press, on the right of assembly and the right of association... as well as restrictions on property, are also permissible beyond the legal limits otherwise prescribed." (Reichstag Fire Decree). Therein is one of the issues with German individualism, it is not absolute nor guaranteed. By allowing individualism to be suspended by the Government, liberty is not protected in a public crisis. Without individual liberty, lots of these other rights many people hold sacred can be sacrificed for the betterment of the collective. The Nazi Party Platform directly follows this course. Point 10 states that "It must be the first duty of every citizen to perform physical or mental work. The activities of the individual must not clash with the general interest, but must proceed within the framework of the community and be for the general good." (Nazi Party Platform). Therbye, individual liberty is abandoned for collective work towards the

general good, as individualism is selfish and lacks general utility. All of these restrictions on individual freedom are only justifiable through the lens of collectivism. The Weimar Constitution allowed the government to violate personal liberty presumably and applicably in the case of collective crisis. The Reichstag Fire Decree was only justifiable as to assure the safety of the German government, and therefore the collective German people as, in the brainwashed eyes of von Hindenburg, they were at risk. Finally, the Nazi party platform argues that individual liberty can often clash with the general good, and therefore cannot be absolutely protected, as its importance is outweighed by the importance of protecting the collective good. A Nazi supporter, Hans B, who had been educated with the individualist French romantics, writes “In our nation the priority is not on the individual and what benefits him but on the common good, the Volk and Germany. We are responsible to future generations.” (Hans B) The Nazis -in creating a common threat from the Jews, Communists, and other groups- established a crisis. Thereby, they could justify the removal of individual liberty to an extreme, as to wish for individual liberty is selfish in the face of a crisis. It is the responsibility -it may even be an absolute obligation- of a decent, moral, noble German to sacrifice his selfish liberty and save the future generations. In the mythos of the Third Reich, as their ancestors did for them. Through a sacrifice of the liberty of the individual, to secure work towards the eventual collective good, liberty as a whole is lost. This is precisely why Germany becomes an anti-liberal authoritarian dictatorship under the Nazis; Hitler can justify control up until the Aryan Utopia saves the collective from the crisis, a far-off utopian dream.

European Collectivism, as it was adopted by Russia

In the onset of the 20th century’s Russian Liberal Intellectual Romanticism, Russians became disillusioned with their formerly beloved autocratic monarchy. Formerly, the majority of Russians were perfectly happy with little liberty and strong adherence to societal norms, hoping for a position in the nobility and to be viewed as socially noble -underneath their adored Tsar of course. Individual liberty was not really desired, and even viewed distastefully. Fyodor Dostoyevsky, in his book *Notes From Underground*, outlines this philosophy in his Russian caricature, the Underground Man. To begin Chapter One of Part Two, the Underground Man speaks on Russian romantics, ultimately determining that “Every decent man [of the 1860s in Russia] is and must be a coward and a slave. That is his normal condition.” (*Notes From Underground* (Pevear and Volokhonsky Translation) Pg 45) This insight is incredibly valuable as Dostoyevsky himself is -for lack of a

better term- incredibly counter culture, and critical of his society's norms, so his view is realistically critical, not diluted by Russian Romantics' love for the "beautiful and lofty" (unrealistic, idealistic descriptions of their state). (Dostoyevsky 47) The caricature of the Underground Man adequately describes the desired and romanticized life of the 19th-century Russian man. He is perfectly content being a coward and a slave, later in the book even arguing that if individual liberty was given to men "[they would] immediately beg to be taken back under tutelage." (Dostoyevsky PG 131) The point the Underground Man makes is incredibly important in foreshadowing the Russian tendency to replace liberalism with authoritarianism nearly instantly after gaining liberty. He argues that the current Russian citizen only wishes to be viewed as noble, and is thereby a slave to society. If society determines nobility, and being noble and decent is the ultimate goal, then sacrificing one's liberty is a minimal loss; furthermore, he argues individual liberty is a hefty responsibility, and so in giving it to a Russian, he will beg to return to subordination, and thereby have fewer responsibilities. In subordination to society, no real decisions must be made, and life is safer; there is a direct and defined path to the eventual goal, and, as the Underground Man describes, the Russian people are pragmatic people seeking "practical goal[s] (some nice little government apartment, a little pension, a little decoration or two)" (Dostoyevsky PG 45) not like American and French idealists who seek non-utilitarian liberal dreams. Ultimately, this being the common psyche of the Russian people is key to why their liberal dreams failed. In 1905, after being disillusioned with the idea of subordination to the Tsar without freedoms, the Russian people actually revolted in hopes of individual liberalism. The byproduct of this revolution was Tsar Nicholas II October Manifesto. The October Manifesto set up an elected parliament and planned "To grant to the population the essential foundations of civil freedom, based on the principles of genuine inviolability of the person, freedom of conscience, speech, assembly and association." (October Manifesto) This presented an incredibly optimistic liberal future for the Russian people, where they would have elected officials and protected personal liberties. However, very little democratic and liberal reform came from this manifesto. This lack of liberty -more so criticized as a lack of desired living conditions- led to a more dramatic revolution, and the rise of the Bolsheviks. The Bolsheviks presented a clear and direct path to the common goal in collectivism, without the hefty responsibility of individualism and self-determination -ideas which had proved futile after the October Manifesto, promising to still keep liberal equality. A Bolshevik supporter Victor Serge describes how "What [the Russian people] want, the party expresses at a conscious level and then carries out. The party reveals to them what they have

been thinking. It is the bond that unites them from one end of the country to the other. The party is their consciousness, their organization.” (Serge) There are no individual desires, as the party reveals what all people want, serving as a collective consciousness and removing the responsibility of individual liberalism. Furthermore, if there aren’t individual desires, then there is no need for individual liberty. This philosophy catches on quickly as it closely resembles the hypothesis of Dostoyevsky’s *Underground Man*. Russians, when they believe individual freedom to be burdensome -as Dostoyevsky describes many do- will easily fall to their knees when confronted with collectivism. The successors of the Bolsheviks, the Communist Party take this collectivism to an extreme. Under their rule, all individualism is shunned, and collectivism becomes the only acceptable ideology. Propaganda posters describe soviet idealism as the power of a “brotherhood.” The use of the term brotherhood insinuates removing yourself from individualism and joining a collective familial society. In figure 1, a soviet propaganda poster from which the quote containing brotherhood derives from, Gustav Klutis illustrates the Russian masses becoming a collective under their leader, thereby losing their individuality, and becoming a collective sea of faces. Furthermore, Russians argue that American individualism is not true freedom. Another poster, figure 2, titled “The Shame of America” presents the image of a single individual dead in front of the backdrop of a heavily populated city, with none of the inhabitants coming to help him. This illustrates the fault of the US being the beloved individualism, as without a collective -in the Soviet worldview- humans will suffer, and none of the self-interested, selfish, greedy, capitalists will come to protect them. However, contrary to the beautiful society hypothesized by Soviet propaganda, and due to the destruction of the individual to promote the rise of the collective brotherhood, liberty as a whole was destroyed. Similar to Hitler, the Soviets claimed that sacrificing your liberty and prosperity was a moral obligation in hopes of achieving the eventual utopia described in the hypothetical last stage of Communism, where no central regulatory authority is necessary, and all are equal.

In Conclusion

The reason why American Liberty has endured is due to the sacred protection of the individual. The reason why collectivism was pushed by many European countries -contaminating individualism, and eventually liberty as a whole- was simple: in societies constantly facing war, it is easiest to rule over a collective hive mind. This is why even the US Military infringes on individualism through the draft, and trains its soldiers to not be individuals, but rather a collective hive-minded war machine. The United States -outside

of the substantial, yet isolated military practices- however, places individual liberty as a fundamental inalienable right as it is vital to liberty as a whole. If Liberty is inalienable, then collectivism can not contaminate and destroy it, and so even if collectivism appears to raise utility to the government at any given time, it cannot really be adopted -mainly for the reason of its innate need to strip individual freedoms, and thereby one's pursuit of happiness. The Nazis and the Soviets, contrary to their propaganda, understood the power of the collective independent of utopian dreams, and did not have safety nets protecting individual liberties holding them back. While the claim made by these groups was that collectivism was necessary to reach the utopia, and that the ends justify the means -this claim may prove to be a true belief in some leaders, especially Adolf Hitler who, it seems, did believe in the Aryan Utopia- it is most definitely not the whole reason behind collectivism. A collective society, where each individual truly believes they are a part of something bigger than themselves, is an incredibly formidable force. It's not a coincidence that these collectivist regimes had incredibly strong military forces, and that these collectivist programs were founded out of a necessity for quick military strength. Part of the reason why the United States has the privilege to secure individual liberty is that America is relatively isolated from threats, and historically has not had to protect itself from capitulation. Therefore, collectivism is not really necessary, and thereby not very appealing to Americans. Europeans, however, do not have this luxury. Historically, there have been countless wars and constant threats in Europe. Due to these dangers, the idea of a strong collective is incredibly romanticized by European governments. If without a collective, capitulation to a stronger force is more likely, then a nation constantly under threat of attack would see incredible utility in collectivism. European Liberalism, due to this fact, is always threatened by the seduction of collectivism, which often becomes exclusive to liberalism as a whole, and therefore is substantially less durable than American Liberalism.

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Figure 1 - "Long live the USSR, model of brotherhood among the workers of world nationalities" 1935 - GUSTAV KLUTSIS



Figure 2 - "The shame of America" 1968 - VIKTOR KORETSKY

PANDA DIPLOMACY

MOLLY O'BRIEN

Milton Academy '26

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For centuries, giant pandas have held special significance in Chinese society. Legends, myths, and art throughout Chinese history often featured the panda. The first documented appearance of the animal can be traced back over 4,000 years to an ancient text. Historical records recount a conflict between two tribes that inhabited the Henan province. One of the tribes used native animals, including pandas, in their battle plans. In China, the panda, particularly its pelt and bones, represented status and wealth. Empress Dowager Bo was buried with a skull, and Emperor Tang Taizong reportedly gifted the animals to his honored guests after a banquet at his imperial palace. Despite the popularity and significance of pandas in China, they were not known to the Western world until 1869. French missionary and naturalist Père Armand David made the first documented sighting by a Westerner in 1896, marking the pandas' introduction to the world stage. A series of Western hunting explorations followed the first spotting. In 1929, Theodore Roosevelt Jr. and Kermit Roosevelt traveled to China in search of pandas. Ruth Harkness, an American fashion designer, captured a panda named Su-Lin in China and brought her back to the United States in 1936. Harkness faced difficulties exporting Su-Lin, so she reportedly listed Su-Lin as a dog in customs to successfully bring her to New York. Su-Lin briefly lived in Harkness's New York City apartment before becoming a major attraction at the Brookfield Zoo in Chicago. She died of pneumonia in April 1938. China used pandas for diplomatic efforts as early as 1941. Chiang Kai-Shek sent two pandas to the United States to thank them for helping Chinese refugees during the war with Japan. Panda diplomacy, however, was not fully utilized until after the fall of the Nationalist government in 1949. Since its

founding in 1949, the People's Republic of China has deployed giant pandas as a show of good faith to international allies and adversaries. In 1957, Chinese Communist Party leader Mao Zedong sent his first "panda ambassadors," Ping Ping and Qi Qi, to the Soviet Union to commemorate the 40th anniversary of the October Revolution. Mao gifted the United States two pandas in recognition of President Richard Nixon's visit to China in 1972. In exchange, Nixon sent two oxen to China. Between 1957 and 1983, twenty-four pandas were gifted to nine different nations. In 1984, Deng Xiaoping changed the policy from panda gifting to panda leasing to maintain control and ownership over the majority of the pandas in the world. All zoos were required to pay China per panda per year and had to maintain the health of the animals. In 1991, China began leasing pandas on a ten-year basis. Historical evidence suggests that China continues to use panda diplomacy because it helps the country boost its international image. Additionally, panda diplomacy promotes wildlife conservation and provides economic benefits for all parties involved. Furthermore, the darker side of panda diplomacy threatens to undermine United States-China relations.

China has long used panda diplomacy as a tool of soft power to enhance its international image. This strategy uses the symbolic value of pandas to strengthen diplomatic ties. China is able to foster goodwill and strengthen bonds with other nations by lending their beloved animals to zoos across the globe. Soft power, as defined by Joseph Nye, is the ability of one country to influence other global nations through persuasion and cultural appeal rather than through force and coercion. Soft power relies on cultural appeal that is considered legitimate and attractive to others across the globe. It aims to encourage a favorable international environment where other nations are more inclined to cooperate and align their interests. American University's School of International Service professor Judith Shapiro states that "the giant panda has been called into service in part because China needs to appear more approachable, softer, and unthreatening." China's political system, and especially its foreign policies, are often viewed as harsh and authoritarian. Pandas helped soften the image of China as more people began to associate them with the lovable pandas. Shapiro continues, saying, "A convergence of factors, including sheer cuteness... and the affections of humans from around the world, have helped to save the animal from extinction and provided China with a powerful diplomatic bargaining chip." The pandas' charm and widespread attraction have created an opportunity for China's diplomatic engagement. China is able to pave the way for deeper diplomatic ties with nations it would have otherwise not had the opportunity to do so by sharing its beloved national animal

with the world. The image of cuddly pandas has been seen on every corner of the globe. For example, as historian and author E. Elena Songster writes in her book *Panda Nation*, "outside of China, the giant panda is a logo for a fast food chain, a software program, a licorice company, and a non-profit environmental organization, among others." Moreover, pandas have become more than just animals on the global stage. They are cartoon characters and symbols of happiness and harmony. Its use in various different medians has demonstrated not only the pandas' broad global appeal but also its commercial value. The panda is a global icon and has marketability, with its value exploited for gain both within China as well as outside. The 2008 Olympic mascot serves as a definitive example of China utilizing the panda to project a positive national image. Ultimately, pandas have become a powerful symbol for China to use, representing the country's cultural heritage and growing influence on the global stage. Xie Feng, the Ambassador of China to the United States, echoes this sentiment, saying in a 2024 interview, "in pandas, we see the Chinese values of harmony, openness, inclusiveness, and shared prosperity. They reflect our two peoples' aspiration for friendship and exchanges, and also the world's longing for peace and cooperation. I encourage our American friends to care for China-U.S. relations just as you care for pandas, cherish the friendship between our two peoples just as you cherish pandas, and protect world peace just as you protect pandas." Moreover, the Chinese government has attempted to use pandas to protect against tensions with other countries. Xie said that pandas reflect Chinese values and paint China as a peaceful nation that wants to see the world move forward in a positive manner. US and China relations rely heavily on the use of pandas in American zoos. If Americans associate China with the soft and cuddly panda, they will be more likely to encourage their government officials to work with the Chinese government. The People's Republic of China's President Xi Jinping is eager to utilize pandas in the diplomatic process. In a 2023 speech, he said, "We are ready to continue our cooperation with the United States on panda conservation and do our best to meet the wishes of the Californians so as to deepen the friendly ties between our two peoples." Xi's emphasis on the Chinese's willingness to meet the needs and wants of the Californians demonstrates China's commitment to fostering positive relationships with recipient countries of pandas. Xi's mentioning that China hoped to deepen friendly ties demonstrates the broader objective of panda diplomacy—to foster closer relationships between nations. In summary, panda diplomacy is a multifaceted strategy that leverages the power of the charismatic panda to enhance China's global image and foster close relationships with panda recipient countries.

Panda diplomacy also plays a significant role in driving improvements in panda wildlife conservation within China. In 1990, pandas were officially declared endangered due to poaching and a decline in habitat. The beginnings of panda conservation, however, started even before the species was officially marked endangered. In 1976, the World Wildlife Fund signed an agreement with China to cooperate on conservation, specifically involving helping save the giant panda habitat. The World Wildlife Fund writes on their website that they were “the first international conservation organization to work in China at the Chinese government’s invitation.” The relationship where international organizations partner on domestic conservation shows the benefit of panda diplomacy. The collaboration between China and international nongovernmental organizations has fostered a better understanding of the best principles in wildlife conservation in China and has helped rescue the panda from endangerment. NGOs, particularly ones based in the United States, have also supported panda conservation. Ambassador Feng said in a 2024 interview that “the San Diego Zoo is the first U.S institution to carry out cooperation on panda conservation with China. When the first panda pair, Bai Yun and Shi Shi, arrived in 1996, that day was said to be the Super Bowl, World Series, and Academy Awards rolled into one. During our 28 years of cooperation, we have jointly developed a panda milk formula and helped increase the survival rates for panda cubs from around 10% to over 90%.” Collaboration between the zoo and China demonstrates the essential role of international partnerships in panda wildlife conservation. The San Diego Zoo has been a major contributor to panda wildlife conservation since the beginning of its exchange. According to the zoo’s website, “Dr. Ya-ping Zhang undertook the first population genetic studies of giant pandas in our Conservation Genetics lab. This groundbreaking study led to a complete analysis of the giant panda studbook population and identification of paternity for many cubs.” Scientists are now able to identify potential threats to the diversity of genes in pandas by analyzing the genetic data collected by the zoo. The study’s contribution to panda conservation is critical because it can help identify stable breeding pairs that can produce panda offspring with high genetic diversity, which will help the population thrive. The findings of the zoo’s study have the ability to improve the effectiveness of captive breeding programs. It also demonstrates the power of conservation genetics as a tool for helping endangered species. Ecologist Liu Jiansu of Michigan State University elaborated on the importance of a partnership between the United States and China on panda conservation, saying that the collaboration “introduced advanced technologies into China’s conservation efforts... Images from US satellites, for example, showed how forests and habitats changed over time on a

large scale.” The transfer of knowledge between two of the world’s biggest superpowers is a positive development, not only for the preservation of pandas but also for diplomatic relations between the two countries. Pandas benefit greatly from the two most technologically advanced countries in the world fighting for their survival. By providing US satellite imagery, scientists from both countries are able to collaborate to monitor habitat loss and track habitat connectivity. Technology plays a crucial role in modern wildlife conservation. Scientists are able to understand the threats facing pandas and develop different and more effective conservation strategies.

Additionally, panda diplomacy provides economic benefits to all parties involved in the exchange. The combination of pandas’ cuddly faces and playful expressions captivates large audiences and makes them an immensely popular attraction to see in person. During the panda’s first year in the United States (1972), according to the Richard Nixon Foundation, “an estimated 1.1 million people came to visit the pandas...and they have remained [a] top attraction for nearly 50 years.” The arrival of pandas at a zoo has a positive impact on the zoo’s economic performance. Pandas lead to a significant surge in attendance, translating to increased revenue from ticket sales. Beyond a rise in admissions, the increased number of visitors leads to greater concession sales and sales of other merchandise. Furthermore, the popularity of pandas as a zoo’s top attraction for 50 years demonstrates their sustained economic impact. The consistent stream of visitors contributes significantly to the zoo’s long-term financial stability. Additionally, the presence of pandas enhances the zoo’s reputation, attracting visitors not only to see the pandas but also to experience the zoo’s other attractions, creating a loyal visitor base that continuously supports the zoo. Zoos are able to capitalize on the public’s fascination with pandas by offering unique and exclusive experiences related to the pandas. For example, at the San Diego Zoo, visitors can book a 60-minute early morning walk with the pandas for \$92 a person. The premium experience demonstrates how zoos can leverage pandas to generate additional revenue. Even zoos outside the United States have experienced elevated incomes once pandas arrive. The Edinburgh Zoo in Edinburgh, Scotland “reported a 200% increase in visitor numbers following the arrival of Tian Tian and Yuan Guang.” The 200% increase in visitors represents a surge in zoo popularity, demonstrating the powerful draw that pandas have on humans. An increase in attendance directly translates to significant economic advantages for the zoo. The zoo’s increased revenue is able to have a ripple effect on the local economy. Visitors may stay in nearby hotels or shop at local businesses, contributing to the overall economy of the region. Additionally, the added prestige that pandas bring to

zoos can lead to increased corporate sponsorships and other philanthropic donations. The economic impact of pandas extends beyond local zoos and local economies. China, the exclusive home to the giant panda, leverages their national treasure to generate economic growth. Currently, only China and Mexico own their pandas. Mexico was gifted its pandas in 1975 and has been able to keep them because of reproduction. Furthermore, as the only owner of an abundance of pandas, China is able to control where they go and for how much money, and is thus a primary benefactor of the revenue they generate. When China loans its pandas, "...zoos have to pay an annual rental fee to China that could be \$1 million a year. Then, it costs an extra \$400,000 if any cubs are born and they must be returned-though not immediately." Pandas are, technically, the property of the Chinese government, as underscored by the fact that all panda cubs must be returned to China within a year of their birth. All of the parties involved in panda diplomacy are able to benefit greatly from its economic impact.

China continues to use panda diplomacy as a strategic tool in its foreign policies. By lending pandas to zoos and countries around the globe, China is able to enhance its global image and continue panda wildlife conservation efforts. Furthermore, China can generate economic benefits for all parties involved in panda diplomacy. Panda diplomacy, however, is not without its drawbacks. By trusting its beloved national treasure to the care of foreign nations and zoo programs, China demonstrates an extreme act of trust. When trust is breached, the consequences can be far-reaching and detrimental to China's relationship with certain countries. In particular, the delicate nature of panda diplomacy has the ability to be extremely damaging to US-Chinese relations, which are already in an increasingly delicate state. A perceived failure to provide only the best care for the panda ambassadors can quickly escalate to a diplomatic crisis. The most prominent example of this occurred at the Memphis Zoo in Tennessee in 2023. In February of 2023, the Memphis Zoo announced that one of its pandas, 25-year-old Le Le, had died, just months after it was announced that the panda would return to China in the coming spring. Critics alleged that Le Le and Ya Ya, his female companion, were living in sub-par conditions in the zoo. Concerns were raised about the quality of bamboo being included in their diet, suggesting a possible struggle with malnutrition for the pandas. The zoo denied the allegations, stating that Le Le was elderly when he died (the average lifespan of a panda is 20 years old) and had died of heart disease. The public was outraged by the death and alleged mistreatment. The controversy gained traction on social media, with many Chinese citizens demanding the early return of Ya Ya to China. Animal rights organizations and activists also demanded

Ya Ya's return, citing concerns about her welfare. Images began to circulate of Ya Ya, appearing thin and displaying signs of possible distress. Her fur was patchy and dull, lacking the vibrant colors seen in healthy pandas, and she was noticeably lethargic. The zoo alleged that Ya Ya suffered from a chronic skin and fur condition and was experiencing a flare-up. In April of 2023, Ya Ya was returned. Her homecoming was met with a wave of emotion within China. The alleged mistreatment soured the relationship between the United States zoos and China. Le Le and Ya Ya's case brought renewed attention to the ethical and moral questions of panda diplomacy and the welfare of pandas in captivity. Some argue that the use of pandas as a diplomatic tool exploits their status as national treasures and the priority of pandas should be for conservation efforts. Nonetheless, panda diplomacy positively affects China, and they likely will not be ending it anytime in the near future.

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THE POLITICAL ECHOES OF ECO-COLONIALISM IN 1970s SUDAN

HT XUE

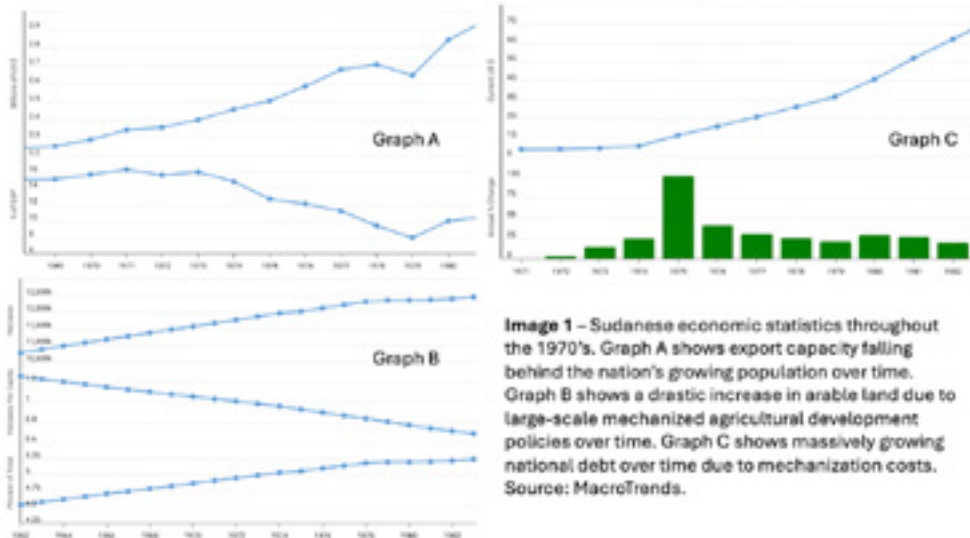
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Introduction

The Sudan that first gained independence from Anglo-Egyptian rule in 1956 would seem politically unrecognizable compared to the Sudan of today. Whereas the former was ruled by a reasonably democratic parliament out of Khartoum focused on domestic capacity-building and consolidation, the latter remains embroiled in one of the deadliest civil wars in the world. Though the semi-violent October Revolution overhauled Sudan's government in 1964, the period of persistent economic decline and ethnic fracturing in the 1970s represented the defining turning point in Sudan's journey from postcolonial democracy to humanitarian catastrophe, as it created the conditions for the Revolution of 1983, which saw the country completely shatter along ethnic lines under the weight of a brutal Sharia Law regime. Indeed, Sudan's 1970s were characterized by falling commodity prices, rising inflation, export declines (as seen in Image 1) due to droughts, and rising economic inequality and alienation between the primarily Arab Jeballa merchant class and the Sub-Saharan African periphery. To explain the root causes of the cataclysmic 1970s, one must look to before 1956, at the Anglo-Egyptian colonial policies that shaped Sudan's physical landscape and ethno-ecology. Colonial policies regulating agricultural exports, water management, and inter-ethnic dynamics destroyed any hope at sustainable development for the sake of resource extraction. Scholars have well documented how the legacies of settler colonialism and colonial macro-management have caused instability in continental Africa, but Sudan presents an apt case study in how extractive eco-colonialism – that is, colonialism motivated and informed by the desire to physically transform a landscape for resource extraction – can shape its postcolonial geopolitical outlook. Ultimately, the restructuring of the Sudanese ethno-ecology by British policies motivated by a colonial

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doctrine focused on resource extraction was the root culprit of the country's economic collapse in the 1970s and the ensuing political turmoil.



Agricultural Policy

First, colonial-era British agricultural policy induced Sudan's government to invest heavily in unsustainably large-scale, mechanized farming that spiraled the nation toward agricultural collapse by making the nation's agricultural infrastructure unable to diversify from cotton exports. Cash crops were first introduced to the Sudanese region under the Ottoman regime, which reigned between 1821 and 1885. Due to the region's fertile riverine land and access to Nile ports, growing and exporting cotton had become a staple of its informal economy by the 1890s. Thus, when the British first drew the borders around what is now known as Sudan in 1899, they saw their new colony primarily as a cash cow from which to generate increasingly lucrative cotton profits and felt little compunction to devote resources to formally administer it, as evidenced by their positioning of Egyptian Arabs as proxy administrators. Such a policy of using a proxy settler to take advantage of the land of Sudan was key as a root cause of the economic turmoil of the 1970s because it left the Sudanese with virtually no sustainable options for postcolonial growth. Specifically, British extractionism materialized in two ways. First, the British "adopted a financial and trading policy that ensured that Sudan's export earnings were always more than the value of its imports," while keeping any export surpluses, preventing Sudanese farmers from

enriching themselves or importing to invest in domestic education or infrastructure and thus precluding farmer skill diversification and perpetually ensuring upward immobility for the black African farmers. Secondly, the British created the Gezira Scheme, a massive 2,700-mile irrigation project by the British which ensured that the very agricultural infrastructure of Sudan was singularly shaped around exporting cotton. In sum, a salient result of British policies was that Sudan's agricultural sector – its farmers and its land – literally could not physically support a path for development independent of simple cotton farming, a reality that set the stage for Sudan's post-independence agricultural policy.

Specifically, Sudan's governments in the 1960s and 70s sought economic growth amidst their newfound independence, but – as a result of the aforementioned colonial policies – could do so only by unsustainably expanding their cotton trade. Seeking to stimulate cotton production, the Sudanese government – itself dominated by the Arab bourgeois merchant class known as the Jeballa – allocated large plots of land previously owned by black subsistence farmers to absentee merchants and politicians while taking loans from the World Bank to mechanize agricultural production. As a result, the size of arable land developed increased drastically throughout the decade, as seen in Image 1, and, by the end of the 1970s, a whopping 4 million feddans stretching across the nation were reserved for mechanized agriculture, all to support mere thousands of largely absentee farm owners at the expense of the land of the millions of traditional subsistence farmers. As a side note, archival evidence suggests that this mechanization process was not only the indirect effect of British ecological management but also directly sponsored by the British regime, as “60 percent of the mechanised farms set up in the 1950s were unauthorised, indicating that the practice had been ongoing for at least half a century”. Problematically, to finance mechanization, the Sudanese government depleted its reserves and resorted to deficit spending and foreign borrowing from the World Bank in particular. As a result, the country's national debt shot through the roof – by 1344% – between 1970 and 1980, as seen in Image 1. Excessive debt financing pushed Sudan into an inflationary spiral; thus, the potential of bolstered agricultural exports to save their currency became their only hope of economic recourse. Devastatingly, agricultural mechanization did the exact opposite: initially induced by the British drive for resource-extractive governance, it led to the nation's economic collapse in the 70s in two specific ways.

First, mechanized farming simply exceeded the land's physical carrying capacity, leading to unstable cotton production throughout the 1970s. While the subsistence economy prior to mechanization used low-technology techniques that “preserved soil fer-

tility” and “exploited rangeland in a rational fashion,” mechanization, by precluding the use of these techniques, ensured mass desertification via soil erosion, land degradation, and deforestation. Moreover, new farms often cut through the routes used by pastoralists to move their livestock between seasonal pastures, debarring the soil-sustainable practice of seasonally mobile grazing, further contributing to soil degradation. Thus, while cotton production overall increased throughout the 70s, it was unstable due to increasingly severe droughts, which introduced cyclical economic downturns that prevented any meaningful economic growth. Moreover, while Sudan’s export volume grew throughout the decade, it failed to keep pace with a rising population, as seen in Image 1, and thus could not support the nation’s economic needs. Ultimately, mass mechanization spiraled out of control as land originally not to be touched was demarcated for mechanization by a government increasingly desperate for private sector growth, in turn hampering production and growth even further and necessitating more land transfers; thus began a vicious cycle of mutually reinforcing agricultural and economic stagnation.

26 Secondly, the fruits of increased agricultural output served only to alienate the rural periphery, as mechanization necessitated the displacement of indigenous farmers, enshrining rising wealth inequality and social unrest. To make way for conglomerate farms, “small producers increasingly had their lands expropriated, and were progressively incorporated into market relations as wage labourers,” a phenomenon with both socio-cultural and economic consequences. Socio-culturally, the development of privatized wage relationships represented a cosmopolitan “new form of social differentiation” that replaced the old patronhood-based relationships that characterized subsistence economies. In other words, the rural periphery was increasingly proletarianized in relation to the Arab Jeballa Bourgeoisie, a relationship which socially disenfranchised the primarily African new proletariat who felt left behind by evolving norms, as evidenced by the formation of Southern separatist movements during this era. Microeconomically, on the other hand, the replacement of subsistence incomes with wage income meant that farmer families were increasingly unable to support their livelihoods, and poverty dramatically shot up during the period. To make things worse, the Jeballa merchants who invested in mechanization primarily “raised capital through mortgageable property or other assets in the urban centers,” increasing property prices and further impoverishing the workers. Macroeconomically, the expansion of commercial farms westward drew away scarce farmworkers from the north, creating labor deficits in the north that increased overall costs and precipitated spending collapse. Of course, these economic effects only exacerbated the aforementioned

social alienation. In all, mechanization displaced black subsistence farmers from their land and forced them into novel wage relations that disrupted traditional social hierarchies and ensured rising inequality and economic collapse. A convergence of this rising poverty and macroeconomic distortion with crop failure – all at the root caused by British extractionist export policies – drove Sudan's economy off the cliff the mounting debt had put it on and into the turmoil it experienced in the 1970s.

Water Management



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Image 2 – Nasser's Aswan High Dam and its potential to flood Nubia; note that the Nile flows north. The Roseires Dam is not pictured, in the Southern Sudd wetlands. Source: The Economist.

Secondly, in simultaneously enshrining an extractionist water management doctrine and Egyptian primacy, British policy led to Egyptian water management programs that exacerbated ethnic tensions and agricultural failures in Sudan. The Sudanese have, throughout their history, been almost entirely dependent on their access to the Nile for agricultural irrigation and for transportation. Despite this dependency, British regional authorities have delegated the administration of Nile water primarily to the Anglo-Egyptian authority and its successors, with little consideration of Sudanese welfare. A desire to streamline and bureaucratize commodity extraction motivated this arrangement; as Barbara Casciarri of the University of Paris points out in her book *Multidimensional Change in Sudan*, “water resources in Sudan have been targeted as part of a more general “great transformation” seeking to turn common spaces, goods, and rooted local forms of communal ownership and management into marketized commodities”; for the British, the best

way to do so was to centralize administration as much as possible, while the Egyptians represented a perfectly situated proxy. The colonists themselves concurred: Colin Moncrieff, a British administrator who worked on irrigation projects in Egypt in the 1880's and 1890's, wrote in a geographic survey of Sudan that "the derelict estate" of Sudan could only produce "money" for the British should it be "irrigated" and optimized to produce "abundant harvests", reflecting the British attitudes of developmentalist macro-management and extractionism. British management of Nile water began in 1907, when Sir William Garstin proposed plans for a canal to divert water from the Sudd wetlands of South Sudan to the Egyptian-ruled north for agricultural purposes, to be named the Jonglei Canal. Though the Jonglei began construction only in the 1950s and was never completed, it represented an early symbol of the British "civilizing mission", prospecting water loss, disease, and flooding in the subsistence-based South for the sake of colonial macro-development. The British began laying the groundwork for later Egyptian projects in 1920, when civil engineer and politician Murdoch MacDonald published his Nile Control scheme for the Ministry of Public Works. MacDonald's proposed a plan to consolidate and streamline regional water resources, named the "Century Storage Scheme". MacDonald's plan would see the water resources of the entire Nile river basin managed collectively to serve British objectives for the region – primarily cotton cultivation – as a whole, as opposed to as individual sub-regions, each with differentiated relationships and uses of the water. Problematically, however, both Egyptian and British objectives for Nile water revolved around industrial projects, like large-scale agriculture and – later in the 20th century – nationwide mechanized water supplying, thus benefiting from efficient macro-management. Sudanese uses primarily involved sustainable subsistence agriculture. Naturally, MacDonald's plan heavily favored the former interests, a bias with reverberations across the next century. Indeed, the core idea of the Century Storage Scheme was passed down across generations of Anglo-Egyptian administrations, shaping the way Arab governors from Egypt and Sudan treated Nile water management long after both nations gained independence.

This kind of water management has led to disastrous consequences for Sudan's ecology and, subsequently, its economy down the line. Perhaps most saliently, in 1959, the recently independent Sudan faced demands from then-Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser to allow the latter to build his flagship nationalist project in the Aswan High Dam, which was projected to displace tens thousands of Nubians through flooding and increasing regional soil salinity and water-logging, as seen in Image 2; Nasser meant for the dam to secure full Egyptian control over its own water flows, as the nation was 98% dependent

on Nile water resources. The then-Sudanese government opposed Nasser's plan and preferred instead a renewed version of MacDonald's Century Storage Scheme, involving a series of smaller irrigation projects across Southern Sudan, including the Jonglei Canal and the Roseires Dam, primarily in order to secure nationwide hydroelectricity. While the two nations preferred opposing plans, both plans would have been partially funded by the then-International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (later the World Bank) with heavy British backing, both were proposed by the Arab administrators the British put in the power, and both were at their core merely different visions of the British model of basin-wide management to the end of regional "development". Thus, they show that the British colonial water model had become fundamental to postcolonial governance in both nations. When General Ibrahim Abboud deposed the Sudanese government in 1958, his new administration consented to the construction of the Aswan High Dam (which was completed in 1971) and to a seemingly fair flow-sharing regime by signing the 1959 Agreement for the Full Utilization of the Nile Waters while continuing existing Century Storage Scheme-esque projects in the South. While scholars mostly agree that the agreement reached in 1959 was a diplomatic success, the combination of both nations' irrigation schemes had the effect of drastically eroding Sudan's ecological health. For one, the wave of irrigation projects did devastating damage to the Nile river bed, reducing biodiversity and increasing water contamination, in turn harming riverside communities directly dependent on Nile water. Moreover, the Aswan High Dam directly displaced over 100,000 Nubians living along the Egyptian-Sudanese border in what was known as "The Nubian Exodus" due to the creation of the new Lake Nasser reservoir. These ground-level effects were felt greatest near where the most intense project were build – Nubian communities in the Sudanese northeast, near the Aswan Dam, and black subsistence communities in the Southern wetlands, near the Roseires Dam; thus, the projects exacerbated ethnic tensions and proletarian alienation, the former of which often spilled over to localized violence and insurgency movements in the 1970s. Aside from direct human impacts, the dams permanently altered the region's soil: it disrupted the cycle of sedimentation and increased soil salinity, slowing soil replenishment in near-riverian agricultural communities while forcing farmers to use crude chemical fertilizers that only decreased soil fertility to replace the silt the Nile flow used to provide. These agricultural effects made the Sudanese agricultural industry devastatingly vulnerable to crop failure during its downturns in the 1970s, drastically contributing to the nation's overall economic woes.

Oil Colonialism

Thirdly, the British separation of a more developed Arab north and a less developed black South, coupled with postcolonial attempts at exploiting Sudan's oil resources, ensured violent North-South civil conflict. The union of Northern and Southern Sudan under one state was, from the very start, an artificial imposition by the Anglo-Egyptian administration. Prior to the colonial period, the people of Southern Sudan overwhelmingly identified with the clan-based cultures of East Africa, while those of the North considered themselves Egyptian and identified with the cultures of the Middle East. In an attempt to develop Sudanese land while minimizing resource expenditure, the British streamlined governance by administering the region as a whole. As a result of this arrangement, the culturally and socially distinct Northern and Southern Sudanese were tied together for post-independence development. Indeed, as British Governor General Hubert Huddleston wrote in a post-independence exit report, "the peoples of the Sudan are distinctively African and Negroid, but the geography and economics combine to render them inextricably bound for future development to the Middle Eastern and Arabicized Northern Sudan". While politically bound together, the two groups remained socio-culturally divided: through British policy, the North-South dynamic had become the main social identity for most Sudanese. As Mahmood Mamdani of Columbia University writes in his book *Neither Settler nor Native*, "the North-South divide seeped into the consciousness of the so-called Arabs and so-called Africans, until it came to seem the natural order of things." British policy lay at the root of this antagonism as it enshrined a power imbalance along ethnic lines: because the Egyptians had been a British colony since 1882 and thus had bureaucrats familiar with British-style governance, the British placed primarily Northern Egyptophile Arabs in positions of power. Arabs throughout the first half of the 20th century were given not just federal power but institutional power at every level of society. Throughout both the North and the South, Northerners became "administrators, senior officers in the army and police, [and] teachers in government schools," while enjoying far higher levels of British developmental investment. The Arabs came to not just dominate the government but also became far more educated and upwardly mobile. As a result, by the 1950s, the Arabs were far wealthier than their Southern counterparts and also controlled the nation's macroeconomy. Moreover, the British, in order to maintain the export surplus in the South that allowed them to extract crops absent reciprocal investment, intentionally strangled trade and thus prevented economic gains from spilling over to the South, imposing the Closed Districts and Permit to Trade orders in the 1920s, which es-

entially created insulated Northern and Southern economies. For the same reason, the British also “encouraged Islamization and Arabization of the north through financial help for building mosques and pilgrimage travel for Muslims” while preventing the spread of Islam in the South by allowing in Christian missionaries who precluded the South from culturally identifying – and thus trading on a large scale – with the Arab states on the other side of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait. The most salient effect of this intentional underdevelopment was that the perception of rising inequality with an antagonistic group prompted Southern unrest.

This antagonism would set the stage for upcoming oil conflicts in the early 1980s. Indeed, the feeling of Southern alienation that incensed the 1983 civil war between the revolutionary Sudan Peoples’ Liberation Army (SPLA) and the Arab ruling government was built throughout the 1970s in relation to conflicting claims over oil in an increasingly oil-dependent state and enabled by various foreign interventions. Oil was first discovered in Sudan, overwhelmingly in the Southern Sudd region and the Southwestern Kordofan, in 1958, when George H. W. Bush, then a US ambassador to the UN, alerted the government of Sudan to US satellite data that indicated the presence of oil in the region. Mass oil exploitation began in the 1970s, when a Sudanese government recovering from a period of instability and beginning to reckon with agro-economic decline granted the American Chevron Oil Company license to spend about 1 billion dollars on extensive seismic testing and the drilling of 52 oil wells in an attempt to shift away from agricultural export dependency. Problematically, however, Chevron’s concessions were granted by the Northern government to exploit oil fields in the South; the former sought nationwide stability but saw no intrinsic value in preventing human violence in the South, especially not in the face of the potential for oil wealth. As a result, lax regulation allowed Chevron – backed by several successive Sudanese governments along with multinational corporations – to violently “clear” the land they were developing of its inhabitants, often involving attacks on Upper Nile communities by Sudanese government militias. Aside from direct displacement, the soil-degradative effects of oil drilling also marginalized land-dependent Southern farmers who increasingly faced little choice but violent resistance. As a result, oil became a major flashpoint for escalating North-South tensions as Southern disillusionment rose. Often, these tensions escalated into violence: as most oil fields in Sudan were “numerous and small rather than few and large”, they became targets for disenfranchised Southern armed resistance groups mobilized by Chevron’s violence; resistance sparked retaliation, and violence became cyclical. In 1980, President Nimeiri’s government broadened the re-

sistance by ignoring vehement Southern opposition to redraw the Heglig and Unity oil fields into the province of Kordofan, enabling Chevron to begin development in those areas. Moreover, whereas Chevron had initially promised to return oil profits to Sudan in the form of private infrastructure investments in the South, convincing the Sudanese government to anticipate becoming an oil state and thus cut spending into other sectors, they reneged on these promises while the Northern government neglected to restrain their violence. As a result, the entire nation economically stagnated as the oil revenue they had become newly dependent on failed to materialize in investments that would make up for lost agricultural output. This economic stress, combined with the Southern perception of Arab-Chevron imperialism, ultimately led to war: In 1983, the SPLA, now a coalescence of smaller Southern resistance movements, attacked Nimeiri's Islamist government, sparking a decades-long series of reciprocal insurgencies that continue to this day. Not only did the SPLA draw most of its support from disillusioned and displaced Southern farmers, the fact that their initial attacks on government infrastructure focused on the most important oil fields demonstrates that cutting Northern oil access was a strategic priority for them, signifying that by this point ethnic tensions in Sudan had become intertwined with the question of oil resource access. In other words, ethnic tensions first enshrined by British policy spiraled into conflict due to the exploitative practices involved Chevron's attempts to extract resources and the nation's crippling oil dependency which, in turn, was also induced by colonial agricultural and water management. Thus, British policy lay at the root of the ethnic antagonisms at the core of violence of the late 70s and the war of 1983; these antagonisms, however, were allowed to spiral into conflict only when placed in relation to natural resource access, thus demonstrating the centrality of resource-extractive colonialism in causing Sudan's conflict.

Conclusion

The beginning of this essay claimed that recently, post-independence Sudan would seem "politically unrecognizable" compared to its modern counterpart. Perhaps the more important story, however, is told by the change in the country's physical landscape: the Sudan of 1899, prior to British rule, would also be ecologically unrecognizable to the modern Sudanese. Half a century of colonialism has transformed much of Sudan's Southern wetlands and Northern grasslands into arid, unusable desert, scattered with Chevron oil rigs, taking with it milenia of indigenous practices. Such drastic change did not follow an ecologically devastating war but was the intentional result of British and then American

resource extraction; the instability and war came after. By fixing Sudan's economy and agricultural sector into hopeless single-crop dependency then setting the government up for unsustainable mechanization, by disrupting the historically important Nile river flow for the sake of streamlining governance, and by turning Sudan into an ethnically divided oil state, eco-colonialism has cemented its place as the root cause of Sudan's cataclysmic 1970s. The indirect violence of eco-colonialism, as seen in Sudan, is similar to direct colonial violence in that it has created devastating political and economic consequences for post-colonial nations but is perhaps even more indicative of the fundamental logic behind colonialism, which seeks to transform complex human landscapes into simple subjects for commodity extraction. Through case studies like Sudan, scholars can understand that violence against nature necessarily translates to violence against humans in a variety of ways. By studying the specific methods and ecological imaginaries through which eco-colonialism operates, we can then begin picturing holistic decolonial methods that account for ecological replenishment and adaptation as parallel to economic and political rebuilding.

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“THERE IS NO GOD BUT ALLAH”

The Lack of Democratic Development in Saudi Arabia

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In 2024, the Freedom House, a non-profit organization that focuses on advancing human rights and freedoms around the world, graded Saudi Arabia as an eight out of 100 on the freedom scale. Saudi Arabia is the second least free country in the Middle East, behind only Syria which scored one out of 100. The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia has been ruled solely by the family of founder Abdulaziz bin Abdul Rahman Al Saud, and no government positions with any meaningful power are elected. Salman bin Abdulaziz Al Saud is the current king, but due to his old age, his son Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman Al Saud serves as the de facto leader. The Al Sauds have lasted so long as the dominant tribe in Saudi Arabia partly due to their pact with the Wahhabis. In 1774, Muhammad ibn Abd al-Wahhab, the creator of Wahhabism, a conservative and severe form of Islam, made a pact with Muhammad ibn Saud, the head of the Al Saud tribal family. The pact stated that the Al Saud family would adopt and promote Wahhabi Islam and in return, al-Wahhab's followers would support the Al Saud tribe politically and economically. Much of the modern success of the Al Sauds in suppressing democratization is due to the structuralist nature of Saudi Arabia. Structuralism is a theory that the institutions and structures of society shape politics and, in this case, are important in maintaining the government's power. Structuralism best explains the lack of democratic development in Saudi Arabia because it allows for the political elites to have total power and for the Wahhabi clerics to have influence in religious and cultural life.

Saudi Arabia has not developed into a democracy because its structuralist government composition gives power to the political elites who find it in their best interest to suppress democratic development. In the history of Saudi Arabia from its formal declara-

tion in 1932 to 2025, the country has been ruled solely by founder Abdulaziz bin Abdul Rahman Al Saud, also known as Ibn Saud, and five of his sons. His 45 sons and approximately 1000 grandchildren now make up the majority of the political elites. Now, all-powerful members of the Saudi government are descendants of Ibn Saud or other members of the Al Saud family. The Al Sauds suppressed democratic development because they feared that elections would lead to the family being ousted from power; "perpetuat[ing] their rule through a skillful combination of distribution, penetration, and coercion, with a legitimating dose of ideology." The Al Sauds use a combination of "carrots and sticks, with religious underpinnings," to remain in power. One example of a stick used by the royal family is imprisonment. In 2012, the Saudi Civil and Political Rights Association called for Saudi Arabia to become democratic and for the removal of authoritarian leaders and the creation of a constitutional democracy. A year later, the Saudi regime sentenced the organization's founders Abdullah al-Hamed and Fahad al-Qatani to at least ten years in prison for "setting up an unlicensed human rights organization." In 1994, the crown revoked Osama bin Laden's citizenship for his criticism of the monarchy. Other times, instead of convicting activists of phony crimes or ostracizing them, the monarchy has used force. In 2018, Saudi Arabian military forces killed journalist Jamal Khashoggi in a Saudi consulate in Istanbul, Turkey. Khashoggi, who was Saudi and lived in Saudi Arabia until he fled in self-imposed exile, published a monthly column in the Washington Post critical of the leadership of the Crown Prince. The Saudi government has at times denied killing Khashoggi, and the Crown Prince said he was not involved or aware of the plan. However, the CIA concluded that the order to kill Khashoggi came directly from bin Salman. Part of the power of the Al Saud family comes from their immense wealth; the government and elites are incredibly rich due to Saudi Arabia's expansive oil fields. Though the country is "an economic powerhouse buttressed by oil revenues," it has "significant poverty among its citizens." Keeping the elites rich and the citizens in poverty hinders democratic development as the public does not have enough resources to try and bring about change and the government has more than enough money to shut democratization down.

The Wahhabi clerics and ulama, the religious authorities, are some of the most important institutions in Saudi Arabia as they lead the country religiously and culturally and suppress democratization and freedom. In return for being loyal to the Al Saud and helping the King maintain cultural control of the country, the Wahhabi are occasionally awarded bureaucratic appointments in places such as the judiciary, education system, and the ulama. The ulama, many of whom are Wahhabi, help the Al Saud control the country;

“it is not clear that the Al Saud could maintain power without their support.” They help suppress democratization as they are resistant to change, “particularly in the sociocultural realm,” and are outspoken about their views. The ulama, as servants of the Crown, help the royal family during times of crises by “[justifying] policy decisions.” The impact of the ulama is that though there are diverse religious sects of Islam in Saudi Arabia, only one, Wahhabism, is “structurally empowered” as it is the official brand of Islam. The message “there is no God but Allah; Muhammad is the messenger of Allah” appears on the Saudi flag, showing how “public discourse is dominated by one particularly austere interpretation, the one that is sanctioned by the state.”

While Saudi Arabia has made small steps towards democratization and freedom as women recently gained the right to drive, the strength of the Wahhabi clerics and ulama and the power of the political elites inhibit democratic development. The ulama control religion and culture in the country and they inhibit democratization by enforcing their conservative views, and the political elites use their power to suppress democratization by controlling their people. Until the Al Saud family decides to completely democratize Saudi Arabia or the Saudi public pressures the Crown towards democratization, the prospect of a strong democracy in Saudi Arabia is bleak.

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FROM DROPOUT TO DIPLOMA

Reducing the Number of Dropouts & Engaging At-Risk Students

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High school dropouts represent a significant challenge in the United States, both socially and economically. Though the reasons behind students' dropping out of school may vary, the long-term consequences of not fully completing high school are extensive for individuals and society. Stacey Teicher Khadaroo's article "Reaching Out to Dropouts" highlights the difficulties many students face and explores the potential solutions to dropouts. This article aims to update these perspectives by investigating the current state of high school dropouts in the United States with a focus on Massachusetts specifically and analyzing the economic consequences of these choices, while examining the critical thinking questions regarding the trade-offs that students face and the importance of engaging at-risk high school students.

High school dropout rates remain a significant issue in the United States, with far-reaching economic consequences. Data from 2025 shows that the overall dropout rate among students aged 16-24 is around 5.1%. Although this number reflects improvement from previous decades, there is still a concerning number of students who leave high school before receiving a diploma. In particular, those who identify as American Indian/Alaska Native have the highest dropout rate at 9.6%. In the state of Massachusetts specifically, the 2022-2023 school year revealed that 2.3% of high school students dropped out of school. Massachusetts is performing better than the national average (5.1%), suggesting that elements such as education policies and access to resources may contribute to the lower rate. However, these 2.3% of high school dropouts in the state of Massachusetts still represent a significant number of students who leave school before receiving a diploma. This statistic highlights that there is still work to do to decrease dropout rates further. According to the

National Center for Education Statistics, the graph below displays the high school dropout rates by race from 2019:

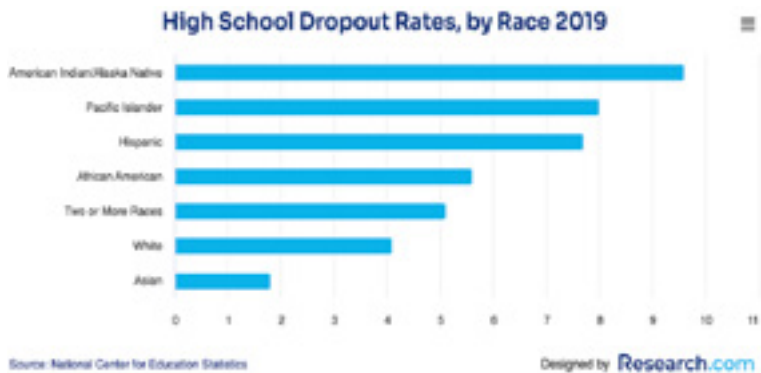


Figure 1: High school dropout rates by race from 2019, with American Indian/Alaska Native having the highest dropout rate at 9.6%.

To incentivize staying in school, schools and governments can make the personal benefits of doing so. For example, financial aid, scholarships, or opportunities to receive college credits can help lower the opportunity cost of remaining in school. Though students tend to perceive the immediate rewards of leaving school as more valuable, these strategies can offer tangible benefits that allow students to shift their focus to the long-term rewards of education. This approach makes the trade-offs between dropping out and staying in school less intimidating, as more students will realize that effort and time spent on education can lead to a more financially fulfilled future. Thus, the chances of students completing their education rise and will benefit both individuals and society. Along with these strategies to help at-risk high school students achieve college credits, programs such as tutoring, mentoring, and counseling can further empower students which can help them navigate challenging coursework and keep them engaged.

While providing incentives to students so that they can complete their education, it is equally important to consider the broader societal costs of dropping out of high school. These costs extend beyond the students who drop out, affecting the public community and resources. Without a high school diploma, individuals are more likely to face unemployment. In addition, data revealed that people who advance in high school levels tend to possess strong skills that can give access to more higher paying jobs. Higher graduation rates are strongly associated with lower crime rates and reduced reliance on government assistance, including food, housing, or unemployment benefits, which creates a more

stable community. As a result, society can save more money and allocate these resources elsewhere.

Reducing the number of high school dropouts is essential for both individuals and society as a whole. By offering incentives like financial aid and opportunities to receive college credits, the opportunity cost will be lower, and students will stay in school while gaining the long-term benefits of education. Additionally, helping at-risk students navigate the trade-offs of completing their education through support programs like tutoring and counseling can provide students with the tools they need to succeed. Ultimately, the societal benefits from staying in school and reducing dropout rates make it clear that investing in the future of education for at-risk students is also an investment in the future of our economy and society. By taking the aforementioned steps, policymakers can help more students to succeed to their full potential.

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The True Cost Of Dropping Out Of High School

THE DIVISION WITHIN THE CHILEAN CATHOLIC CHURCH

During Augusto Pinochet's Regime

1973 to 1988

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Established in 1956, the Chilean Roman Catholic Church shared common goals with the Chilean central government for decades. Both institutions supported stability, order, and social harmony and opposed radical political movements, common interests which made them natural allies with each other. However, this relationship between the church and state shifted in 1973, when General Augusto Pinochet staged a coup d'état on previous Chilean president Salvador Allende and established a military junta. As Pinochet's dictatorship and the junta's human rights abuses continued, the church took a more distinct role in the political and social state of the people of Chile. During this time, the major leaders of the Catholic Church in Chile were Cardinal Archbishop Raul Silva Henriquez in the first ten years and Juan Francisco Fresno during the last five years, both serving under Pope John Paul II, the head of all Catholic Churches worldwide. Many individuals within the layers of the Catholic Church hierarchy formed vastly different attitudes towards the regime: while some held mediatory roles and condoned the junta, many found themselves in full-blown opposition against Pinochet. The coexistence of the non-confrontational attitudes toward Pinochet of both the Pope and Cardinal Fresno from 1983 to 1988 versus the highly assertive and confrontational approach of Cardinal Silva from 1973 to 1983 fueled the central divide between mediation versus the confrontational attitudes in the Chilean Catholic Church.

For the first ten years of the regime, from 1973 to 1983, despite the conflicting voices of the conservatives within the catholic church, Cardinal Silva, an exception to the other leaders of the Chilean Church, publicly denounced Pinochet and actively opposed the regime. The cardinal directly served both the Pope and the Archbishop of Santiago, the

most important Catholic leader in Chile. In contrast with both the Pope and the later Cardinal Fresno, Cardinal Silva used his power to publicly oppose Pinochet's junta right from the beginning by issuing public statements at the start of the regime in 1973 and 1974. On September 11th, 1973, just thirteen days after the coup, obvious human rights violations had already begun. Visible mass detentions appeared in the National Stadium of Santiago and hundreds of detainees were requesting help from the Church and the Catholic priests. When Cardinal Silva visited the stadium, he recalled that he was "unable to hold back his tears" due to the unbearable conditions there. Then, in his first public announcement actively supporting human rights, he said to the prisoners in the large speakers, "I am the representative of a Church that is the servant of everyone, especially of those that are suffering. I want to serve you and like the Lord, I do not ask who you are or what are your beliefs or political positions. I put myself at the disposal of the detainees." His words revealed that he will take an active role in ensuring human rights, while the fact that he is making his pro-peace and anti-junta stance clear just thirteen days after the coup—before the Chilean church figured out how to establish ties with the junta—suggests his strong desire to resist Pinochet and the horrific crimes the government committed towards the Chilean people. In addition, on April 24th of 1974, after seven months of even more tortures, disappearances, and mass detentions, Cardinal Silva issued "a declaration accusing the military junta of the use of torture, arbitrary and lengthy detentions, of making job dismissals for political reasons," calling for "such situations" to "be overcome only by the unrestricted respect for human rights as formulated by the United Nations and the Second Vatican Council." This document, supported by most bishops in Chile, directly accused the Chilean junta in extremely overt language of the human rights violation they have committed, demonstrating Silva's use of his power in the Church to oppose the government's actions. However, not all bishops and archbishops in Chile fully supported the cardinal's decision to overtly acknowledge that the junta had committed human rights violations. On May 20th, 1974, just 24 days after Silva's document was distributed, an originally classified telegram from the CIA notes that Valparaiso's Archbishop Luis Antonio Tagle had issued a "pro-junta" and "anti-marxist" statement himself, while archbishop of La Serena, Juan Francisco Fresno also issued a statement supporting government policies such as "granting land to peasants [and] farming workers' cooperatives". Both statements by the conservative archbishops "completely ignore[d] the issue of human rights violations which originally prompted" the April 24th declaration by the Cardinal. The fast 24-day response of both Tagle and Fresno reveals the hidden dissent within the Chilean Church. Yet, these conflicting voices were

overpowered by Cardinal Silva's active opposition towards the regime after the first half of 1974.

During this time, Cardinal Silva was also a strong advocate for the rights of Chileans through his action with the organization Pro Paz and the founding of the Vicaria de Solidaridad (Vicariate of Solidarity) under the church. The Comité de Cooperación Para La Paz (Pro Paz) was founded in 1973 by the various Churches across Chile and headed by Cardinal Silva. Originally, the Churches believed it was a temporary response to the changing government that wouldn't last past a few months. Yet, just in the twelve months of 1974, as human rights abuses escalated, the original eight workers increased to 103 in Santiago and 95 elsewhere in Chile. By the end of this two year period, Pro Paz, led by the Cardinal, had offered 40,000 Chileans legal services, provided 70,000 Chileans with medical assistance, and fed 35,000 children every single day. Cardinal Silva's direct action on behalf of the human rights of all Chileans on such a large scale in such a short amount of time expresses his open resistance to Pinochet's restrictions. This act of resistance was also met by response from Pinochet, who required Silva to shut down the organization. Though the cardinal had to comply, he initiated another organization in January of 1976 - Vicaria de Solidaridad (Vicariate of Solidarity) - under the Pope and the Chilean Church to continue the work of Pro Paz, preventing the state from interfering as the church is considered a "person of public law". Under Silva's leadership, in the one year of 1976, its facilities provided 5 million meals for starving Chilean children. In addition, within the year from 1976 to 1977, it continued to provide 250,000 people with legal services and 700,000 people with occupational services. The continuation of Silva's immense, direct, and active efforts to resist repression and specifically assist victims of the regime, a bold exception to other powerful Catholic leaders, reveals his strong and impactful opposition attitude towards the junta despite conservative voices within the church.

While Pope John Paul II supported human rights efforts and the democratization of Chile, he still maintained a reconciliatory and non-confrontational attitude towards Pinochet and the junta during his visit in 1987, creating divides within the Church. While the pope was the most powerful leader in the Catholic Church hierarchy, his influence on the people of Chile and the junta was limited to this visit, marking the complex, yet smaller role he played in the Church's relation with the Pinochet regime. On April 1st, the pope flew from Rome to Chile: with his slogan being "El amor es más fuerte" (love is stronger). The goal of this pilgrimage was to reconcile the division between Pinochet's junta and the Catholic Church as well as express a message of peace, especially during a politically

tense period of time with increased disappearing and kidnappings by the junta as well as an attempted assassination and attacks by the Communist-marxist guerrilla organization Manuel Rodriguez Patriotic Front (FPMR) from 1986 to 1987. At first, the Pope recognized the work of the Vicariate of Solidarity, founded by Silva in 1977, for its “devotion on behalf of human rights”. On the second day, in his speech to a conference of 31 Chilean bishops, he “affirmed the rights of people everywhere to take part in political life and elect their leaders”, Washington Post stated on April 3rd, 1987. Despite these papal indications of support towards those who oppose the junta, he balanced this support with suggestions for the church to take a non-confrontational approach, his cordiality with Pinochet, and even his backing for some of the junta’s policies. While promoting free elections on his second day, the Pope also “advised his bishops to refrain from engaging in politics”, emphasizing that the church “identifies with no political party,” according to the Washington Post. United Press International (UPI) also headlined their article on April 11th, 1987, “Pope avoids confrontation with Pinochet.” Both sources suggest that instead of publicly condemning Pinochet, the pope took a more cautious, mediation-based approach towards interacting with the regime and encouraged the Church to do the same. During the six-day visit, the pope also directly met Pinochet, with a symbolic appearance of the pope and Pinochet, “dressed in a civilian suit, smiling and standing one step behind him.” The pope also offered prayers for Pinochet and his family after their conversation, displaying non-confrontational cordiality to the general.

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Augusto Pinochet and Pope John Paul II stood on Pinochet’s balcony, a symbolic appearance of reconciliation and mediation.

AFP. Chile-Pinochet 5. Photograph. Getty Images, April 2, 1987

Finally, the pope voiced his support for Pinochet's anti-communist beliefs, concurring with the denunciation of "foreign influences" that are "distort[ing] the national will." Hence, most of the Pope's actions during his visit expressed and encouraged a cautious attitude towards Pinochet and the junta, despite somewhat supporting the work the Chilean Catholic Church has done. Still, this visit to Chile, spanning only six days, albeit important, did not contribute to the division within the catholic church quite as significantly as the two domestic cardinal archbishops, simply echoing the attitude of Cardinal Fresno's Chilean Catholic Church and his stance towards the regime.

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For the final five years of the regime, from 1983 to 1988, even with increasing human rights violations, Cardinal Fresno, similar to the pope, played the role of a cautious and steadfast conciliator between the church and the regime. Cardinal Fresno, a respected moderate and former archbishop of La Serena, Chile, succeeded Cardinal Silva in June of 1983. Even leading up to this moment, there continued to be an immensity of human rights abuses, such as the detention of "some 200 protestors" within a day on December 19, 1982, and "more than 1,000 people [who] were reportedly detained" in the months leading up to December. Though Cardinal Fresno "affirmed his support for programs such as the Vicariate of Solidarity", he refrained from denouncing Pinochet or directly condemning the human rights abuses of the junta. While the military government's attacks continued, anti-government protests in Chile also increased, exactly when Fresno was appointed Cardinal during the summer of 1983. Instead of directly supporting these protests, Cardinal Fresno sponsored "a dialogue between government officials and moderate opposition leaders", specifically between the newly appointed Minister of Interior, Sergio Jarpa, himself and the Democratic Alliance. However, soon, his mediation attempt failed as Jarpa and other government officials resigned amid a government crisis. Still, Fresno continued his role as a mediator in early 1985, after some bishops agreed in late 1984 to help unite political parties. He continued to hold "bilateral meetings with selected party leaders on the subjects of reconciliation" secretly in his residence, involving former president Eduardo Frei's cabinet member Sergio Molina, former Minister of Treasury Fernando Leniz, businessman Jose Zavala, Christian Democrat Patricio Aylwin, and president of Chilean Senate Gabriel Valdes. Together, instead of directly opposing the junta, they drafted a document named "the National Accord on the Transition to Full Democracy", which was made public on August 26th, 1985. The Accord avoided many "controversial" subjects, such as acknowledging human rights violations and the calling for trial for those who com-

mitted these abuses, revealing the cautious and more conservative stance of its leader, Cardinal Fresno. Although not as direct, active, or forceful as Cardinal Silva, Cardinal Fresno still played a dominant role, amid human rights abuses, attacks, and a government crisis, in facilitating non-confrontational reconciliation between the church, the junta, and the general Chilean society from 1983 to 1988.

In the end, the contrast between Cardinal Silva's active and directly confrontational work for human rights and to resist the regime from 1973 to 1983 with the cautious and conciliatory stances of both the Pope in 1987 and Cardinal Fresno from 1983 to 1988 created a major shift in the Church's relationship to the Pinochet regime. Looking back at the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, it is intriguing how the impact of both Cardinal Silva and Cardinal Fresno largely outweighed that of Pope John Paul, who is considered the most influential for all Catholics and Catholic churches. Even more fascinating is that the division between mediators and adversaries in the church did not weaken its influence. Instead, despite taking different approaches, Silva's being an active advocate for the people while Fresno's being a private conciliator for reconciliation, both of their stances and actions contributed largely to success of the impending plebiscite in the "vote no" movement that ended the fifteen-year dictatorship in 1988, propelling Chile into an era of democracy and freedom.

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THE ELECTION OF DONALD TRUMP

Examining the 2016 Presidential Election

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The election of Donald Trump in 2016 was a significant political event for the United States due to Trump's unexpected win that reshaped political norms and party alignments. Trump's election can be best explained through the framework of right-wing populism and nationalism, both of which have affected American political culture. Right-wing populism is a political ideology that combines right-wing politics with populist rhetoric, emphasizing nativism and anti-globalization sentiments. Right-wing populism brings the people together into one pure nation; in order for the nation to be perceived as pure, right-wing populism typically has sentiments of anti-globalization and anti-immigration. Through this framework, Trump was able to win over many white working-class voters who believed that politicians from both parties had abandoned them. Donald Trump's election in 2016 was driven by right-wing populism and nationalism, which resonated with voters' economic grievances, cultural anxieties, and anti-elite sentiment.

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In the United States, the political culture has typically emphasized individualism, nationalism, and skepticism toward the upper class and political leaders. Economic individualism and self-reliance are important aspects of American identity, influencing citizens' views on economic policy and government involvement. As a result, economic hardships in the U.S. linked to globalization and the decline of industries are perceived as a personal betrayal of the American Dream. Trump recognized these sentiments and capitalized on them by presenting himself as a member of the working class, a man of the people, and someone who shared the classic American rags-to-riches story that resonated with many voters. Nationalism has also influenced American identity by creating resistance to globalization and immigration. Trump's campaign emphasized "America First," which played into the fears that foreign influences were threatening national sovereignty. Trump's anti-immigration stance appealed to the 62% of white working-class citizens who believed the growing number of immigrants was threatening American culture. One of Trump's

most controversial proposals was to build a wall along the U.S.-Mexico border, a concrete symbol of his anti-immigration campaign. 65% of Americans believe that political candidates run for office solely with the purpose “to serve their own personal interests.” This can lead citizens to feel their leaders are unbothered by the needs of ordinary citizens. Trump used this distrust as a way to connect with voters who felt their voices were ignored by the political class. Trump separated himself from political leaders by criticizing the Washington elites, which legitimized himself as the best candidate.

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Economic grievances were central to Trump’s appeal in the election. A core element of American political culture is the belief in individual success and upward mobility. However, due to the economic restructuring of the late 20th century and early 21st centuries --driven by globalization and automation-- there were many job losses, particularly for those working in the manufacturing and industrial sectors. The economic disenfranchisement is pronounced in the Rust Belt, where 28% of manufacturing jobs were lost. This led working-class Americans to feel abandoned by both Republican and Democratic leaders because they felt neither party was addressing their needs or concerns. Trump’s economic populism targeted these voters, presenting himself as a businessman capable of restoring lost jobs and economic prosperity. By positioning himself against economic elites and globalist policies, Trump tapped into the belief that hard work should lead to success, reinforcing the American ideal of self-reliance. This message resonated particularly among white voters without college degrees, who felt that traditional political leaders had failed them. Those without college degrees have fewer opportunities for upward mobility and, as a result, experience the economic decline --specifically the loss of manufacturing jobs-- more so than those with higher education and status, such as political leaders. These voters were more likely to view political leaders as disconnected from their struggles, given that many political leaders come from backgrounds of higher education and professional success. This perception intensified the appeal of Trump and his campaign.

In addition to economic grievances, cultural anxieties played a role in Trump’s election. American political culture has long been shaped by nationalism and cycles of nativism, particularly during periods of rapid demographic and social change. Trump’s nationalist rhetoric capitalized on these anxieties, portraying immigration and globalization as threats to American identity. In a study conducted by PRRI, “White working-class voters who say they often feel like a stranger in their own land and who believe the U.S. needs protecting against foreign influence were 3.5 times more likely to favor Trump than those who did not share these concerns.”

Trump's slogan, "Make America Great Again," evoked nostalgia for a past that many citizens believed was better. This appeal to traditional values was particularly effective among the white voters who felt their cultural and economic status was declining. Studies have shown that concerns over cultural displacement, rather than purely economic hardship, were strong predictors of Trump support. This highlights that economic factors were not the only reason for Trump's election.

Populism has been a recurring presence in American politics, challenging the established upper class and political leaders and advocating for the interests of the "common man." Trump's campaign embraced this tradition, positioning him as an outsider fighting against a corrupt political and media system. Trump's attacks on Washington elites, career politicians, and the mainstream media were central to his appeal to American citizens because he was able to separate himself from "political elites" and legitimize himself as the next presidential candidate. By framing the election as a battle between the people and a corrupt elite, Trump tapped into a long-standing distrust of centralized power. Many Americans were tired of feeling ignored by those in power, and Trump's campaign gave them a voice.

Donald Trump's election in 2016 is best explained through the framework of right-wing populism and nationalism, which influenced the American political culture. Trump's campaign addressed economic frustrations, cultural anxieties, and anti-elite sentiment, resonating with voters who felt neglected by other political leaders. His campaign's focus on individual success and economic issues made the "common man" see their struggle as betrayals of the American Dream, which increased and strengthened support for Trump's populist message. In addition, Trump's focus on nationalism and cultural identity concerns fueled anti-immigration and anti-globalization sentiments, reinforcing his "America First" messaging. Finally, the deep-rooted distrust of elites allowed Trump to position himself as a political outsider willing to challenge and fight against the elites. The persistence of right-wing populism and nationalism suggests that these tensions will likely remain central to future political movements and electoral outcomes in the U.S.

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PROGRESS IN GYNECOLOGICAL ADVANCEMENTS

But At What Price?

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The history of medical advancement has been marred by numerous instances of unethical experimentation with some of the most egregious violations carried out on marginalized populations. Among these, black people have been disproportionately subjected to invasive, often coercive, medical practices without their consent. This dark legacy reveals a troubling intersection of racism and research, fundamentally questioning the ethical foundations upon which some medical advancements were built. From the non-consensual gynecological experiments conducted by J. Marion Sims in the 19th century to more contemporary abuses such as the Tuskegee syphilis experiment and Henrietta Lacks. The experiences of black people have exposed a pattern of exploitation. These instances of medical experimentation highlighted a critical need for a reevaluation of practices and policies to ensure that such injustices are never repeated. The medical experiments on female slaves in Antebellum America reveal the profound impact of exploiting their bodies for experimentation. The methods used by practitioners like J. Marion Sims highlight the dehumanizing and unethical nature of such practices in the pursuit of medical knowledge. The brutality and inhumanity of Sims' experiments led to a reassessment of his legacy because of the way he achieved success through his exploitation of non-consenting women.

Human medical experimentation has a complex and often controversial history, marked by both groundbreaking advances and profound ethical dilemmas. Historically, the lack of stringent regulations allowed for experiments that, while contributing to medical knowledge and the greater good, often compromised the well-being and rights of the people being experimented on. J. Marion Sims became known as the "father of gynecology." A review of his experiments on female slaves in Antebellum America reveals the repeated and reprehensible abuse of their bodies for experimentation in order to achieve his medical breakthrough. When viewed through the lens of 21st Century morals and ethics, Sims' work in gynecology, while groundbreaking, is seen as being attained at the cost of de-

humanizing and exploiting his unconsenting patients in the pursuit of medical knowledge.

Sims made significant contributions to the field of gynecology by developing a cure for vesicovaginal fistulas which are a severe complication of childbirth. He is also credited for developing many gynecological tools (Figure 1), the first speculum, a commonly used gynecological tool today, and the catheter. In recent years, Sims' methods have been scrutinized, leading to a change in public opinion about his place in history. Between 1845 and 1849 Sims conducted experimental surgeries on enslaved black women without their consent and without anesthesia, factors that raise significant ethical questions in more modern times. In 2018, following a review of controversial statues by a mayoral commission in New York City, Sims' statue was removed from Central Park and moved to his burial place in Brooklyn. The commission noted "There is no question about the abuse of the women he experimented on." This follows the removal of a painting of Sims from the University of Alabama, Birmingham in 2016. The legacy of Sims is dual-edged, balancing medical advancements against the need for ethical standards and informed consent in medical research. This shift has gradually taken shape over the years, leading to more rigorous consent policies created by ethical review boards in medical research today.

Sims became interested in treating vesicovaginal fistulas after noting the occurrence while treating a patient for an unrelated injury. A vesicovaginal fistula is a devastating condition resulting from prolonged or obstructed childbirth, where a hole forms between the bladder and the vagina, leading to the continuous, involuntary discharge of foul-smelling urine into the vaginal vault, severe social stigma, and health complications. At the time, there was no cure. To research the ailment, Sims needed bodies to experiment on. In 1845 he successfully negotiated with slave owners to experiment on their slaves "the owners agreeing to let me keep them (at my own expense) till I was thoroughly convinced whether the affection could be cured or not." Slaves were the property of their slave owners and it was the slave owner's consent, not the consent of the slaves themselves that Sims legally required for his experiments. A vesicovaginal fistula impacted a slave's ability to work and have more children and therefore, diminished their value or 'soundness' to their owner. "Being" sound "meant" they produce (for men and women) and reproduce (for women). For these women having this fistula made them less sound." Profitability and work output were of utmost interest to the slave owners, not the suffering and indignity of injuries caused by childbirth.

Whether these women wished to undergo treatment is unknown, and this is the crux of the power imbalance. They had no autonomy over their own lives and bodies. The

inherent authority of the slave owners and a White male physician was wielded unethically against enslaved women. Sims wrote in *The New York Medical Gazette and Journal of Health* in January 1855, “For this purpose [therapeutic surgical experimentation] I was fortunate in having three young healthy colored girls given to me by their owners in Alabama, I agreeing to not operate without the full consent of the patients, and never to perform any that would, in my judgment, jeopardy life, or produce greater mischief on the injured organ” Whether the women were actually empowered to agree or disagree to participate in the research and treatments is questionable given the norms of the Antebellum era. As noted by the New York City Commission, “Free consent to participate in the experiments was not obtainable from women who were not free.”

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Sims conducted experiments on twelve patients but of these women, only three are named in his records. They are Anarcha, Betsey, and Lucy. “I got three or four more to experiment on, and there was never a time that I could not, at any day, have had a subject for operation. But my operations all failed ... this went on, not for one year, but for two and three, and even four years.” All of these women endured numerous surgeries under excruciating conditions. We know from Sims’ autobiography *The Story of My Life* that Anarcha endured thirty surgeries. Anarchy’s was the only successful surgery after 3 years of experimentation. There is no information on how long Anarcha lived post-operation as her day of death had not been recorded. Over time, as Sims’ experiments continued to fail, the support of his medical peers fell away. Even his wife begged him to stop. Sims however was undeterred, and in the absence of professional medical assistants, his remaining course of action was to train Anarcha, Betsy, and Lucy to be his assistants during surgery and assign them to nurse each other and other patients during the post-surgery recovery period. Again, the women would not have had a choice on their work assignments. While residing with Sims, he had full authority over their bodies and their day-to-day activities.

The dehumanizing treatment of enslaved female patients in the operating room highlights the ethically concerning lack of respect and dignity perpetrated on the women under the guise of medical treatment and research. During surgery, the women were naked, strapped to a table, or held down in order to minimize their movements. In some instances, they were operated on in front of a room of White men. Their consent to be subjected to scrutiny by a room full of strangers was not contemplated. During the surgery, the patient faced forward on her knees, with her forehead resting on her hands. This position became known as ‘the Sims position’ There was no consideration for her right to privacy or dignity.

Pain management, or lack thereof during surgery is another example of how these women were dehumanized and abused. In line with the thinking of the time that Black people had a strong tolerance for pain, no anesthesia was administered. In his autobiography, Sims noted “Lucy’s agony was extreme. She was much prostrated, and I thought that she was going to die”. Anesthesia was not commonly used by physicians during the period of Sims’ surgical discovery. Durrenda Ojauna writes, “Sims was unaware of the advances which have been made in this area of medicine.” Many physicians also believed that patients could die if given anesthesia for their procedure. However, at the time of these experiments, there were other common anesthetics used during the Antebellum era but Sims did not see a need to use these methods of pain relief for his Black patients. For example, alcohol and opium were often used during pre-anesthetic surgery. These pain management options were known to be especially common during the Civil War which occurred after his experiments. One may argue that while anesthesia was not yet a reliable pain blocker, Sims could have used other sources of pain management medicine, but chose not to, in consideration for his patients.

After four years of experimentation, Sims finally perfected the surgery. When publicly reporting on his achievement, Sims omitted to acknowledge the role of the black slaves, either as patients or medical assistants. It should also be noted that when performing the surgery on white women, anesthesia was used. One theory is that White women received anesthesia because its use was more widespread by the time the surgery was perfected. Another line of thinking is the belief that white women had a lower tolerance for pain when compared to Black women. Today, discussing the reasoning behind Sims’ refusal to administer pain medication is the subject of debate. What is not debatable is the pain the women endured.

Although celebrated as “The Father of Gynecology” Sims practiced in different fields such as dentistry, pediatrics, and general surgery. While experimenting on the enslaved women, he also extended his experiments into pediatrics. He mentioned in his autobiography, “I prefer researching children.” His experiments on black children would today be classified as barbaric. It was a belief commonly held at the time that Black people were less intelligent compared to Whites due to the misconception that their skulls grew too quickly around the brain which was thought to be a symptom of lockjaw. In an effort to cure lockjaw or neonatal tetanus, Sims operated on infants using a shoemaker’s tool in an attempt to pry their bones open and loosen their skulls. The underlying cause of neonatal tetanus is malnutrition which was common among slaves and many children died as a re-

sult of his brutal treatment.

Ultimately, Sims did not care about positively impacting the lives of the slaves. He cared about his legacy and how his discoveries would enhance the lives of the white females who also suffered from vesicovaginal fistulas. When he had perfected his medical procedure, he sent Anarcha, Betsey, and Lucy back to their plantations and moved to New York where he opened the first-ever Woman's Hospital in 1855. There, he continued to repair fistulas using anesthesia and gained a very positive reputation. However, if patients experienced any complications from surgery, he took no accountability, blaming instead "the sloth and ignorance of their mothers and the Black midwives who attended them." Sims always had slaves to blame for his own errors.

At the start of the Civil War, Sims moved to Paris and continued to perform his life-changing surgery all over Europe, counting European royalty, including the Empress of Austria, among his patients. He returned to New York at the end of the Civil War and ultimately set up a private practice. In 1876, he became president of the American Medical Association and died in 1883.

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By conducting research on enslaved women without their consent, and using their bodies to perfect his methodology, J. Marion Sims repeatedly abused his medical authority. His actions also entrenched a dangerous precedent of ethical disregard that has echoed through medical history. This historical abuse underlines the urgent need for ongoing vigilance and reform in medical ethics to prevent the recurrence of such injustices and ensure the protection of all patients' rights. Sims' experiments resulted in everlasting advancements in gynecology, in the treatment of vesicovaginal fistula, and in the development of medical tools. Before Sims' work, there was no effective treatment or cure for the condition. Women suffered desperately both physically and mentally and they were shunned and isolated. He received global recognition for his achievements but the human cost of his success was not considered.

In recent years, Sim's advancements in gynecology have recently been equally credited to "The Mothers of gynecology," Anarcha, Betsy, Lucy, and the other unnamed heroines. The strength and resilience displayed by these women contributed to why many females are now living without this dreadful post-natal injury. Whereas in the past, statues and monuments were raised in honor of Sims, today, the contributions of Anarcha, Betsey, and Lucy are being celebrated in statues, paintings, and plaques. As we have learned, they were not just passive 'guinea pigs' being experimented on; they were also trained and skilled surgical assistants and nurses. Acknowledging the inhumane treatment of margin-

alized women in medical history is crucial, not only for acknowledging these grave injustices to begin the healing process, but also to ensure that their contributions and strength are not overlooked.

Was Sims a monster or a man of his time? His legacy is today overshadowed by the ethical implications of his methods, specifically the absence of informed consent, empathy, respect for the patient, and respect for their dignity. While the suffering endured by the women he experimented on cannot be disputed or forgiven, Sims' approach to experimentation and research was the norm during that period.

Sims grew up in and practiced medicine in the Antebellum South. Slaves were property, with no rights or freedoms. Decisions regarding their existence remained solely at the discretion of the slave owner. Medical experimentation on enslaved people was encouraged without penalty or recourse. The South Carolina Medical Office even set up a medical office to enable medical experiments on both free and enslaved blacks. The purpose of the rooms was not to improve the lives of the patients, but instead to promote medical education. Sims didn't feel it necessary to document the names of all the slaves he experimented on. To him, they were just bodies, not worthy of recognition. Having perfected his techniques, he did not publicly acknowledge the role played by Anarcha, Betsey, and Lucy as his medical assistants in his experiments. After years spent perfecting his technique, these women were discarded and sent back to their owners.

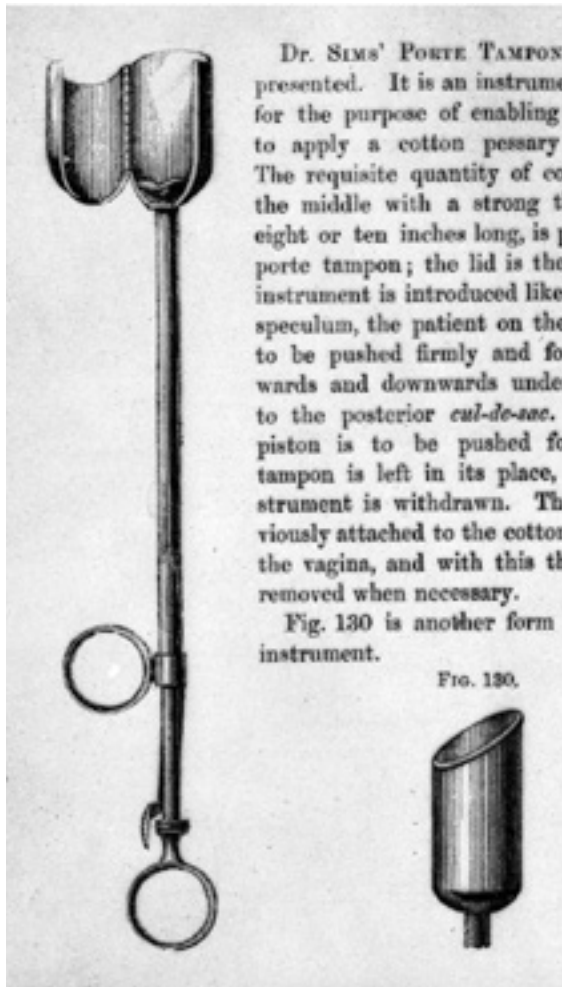
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Sims also subscribed to the common thinking at the time that Black people did not feel pain the same way as Whites, ignoring the obvious distress and suffering of his patients. Having finally and successfully cured Anarcha, he attempted the same surgery on three White women, but in all cases, had to halt the surgery because the women could not endure the pain. It could be argued that in the case of White women, he recognized their duress, but for his Black patients, he was doggedly determined to complete the surgery.

Sims' work serves as a critical reminder of the importance of ethics in medical research, emphasizing that the ends do not always justify the means. There are basic human rights that should be granted to each human being and not ignored for the greater good. Sims and many others throughout history looked away from that view and treated their patients with brutality, as if they were not even human. Sims' experiments catalyzed not only advancements in medical tools and techniques but also the development of ethical standards that aim to protect patients in clinical research and practice. Sims' torturous experiments stemmed from the lack of humanity his eyes had on the world. The three women especially lived their lives in pain so the future of females could be restored.

Equitable practices are recognized as being essential in modern medicine. By understanding and acknowledging past abuses, such as those perpetrated by J. Marion Sims, society is better positioned to enforce guidelines. Today, patient autonomy is safeguarded, and informed consent is required and prioritized, thereby preventing the repetition of such historical atrocities and fostering a more just medical community. Contemporary medical practices are grounded in ethical principles and respect for all human beings.

Figure 1



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SURVIVING DEPORTATION AND LIVING THROUGH THE RAMIFICATIONS

The Kalmyk Story

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Introduction

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The Kalmyk deportation, orchestrated by Stalin's People's Commissariat for Internal Affairs (NKVD) during World War II, stands as one of the most calculated and devastating episodes of Stalinist repression. Code-named "Project Uluses" by Soviet Authorities, the operation targeted the entire Kalmyk population with accusations of collaboration with Nazi forces during the German occupation of the Kalmyk Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic (ASSR). The term Uluses, in Kalmyk, defined as "large regions" or "people," carries a grim symbolic weight: it underscores clear Soviet intent to obliterate not just the Kalmyk individuals but the entire Kalmyk people.

The Kalmyks are a Buddhist majority ethnic group, descendants of the Oirats, a western Mongol group. In the early 17th century, a group of Oirats began a westward migration from their homeland in Dzungaria (present-day Xinjiang, China). By 1630, they had reached the steppes of the lower Volga River and the Caspian Sea, in what is now southern Russia. In 1771, most of the population decided to return to Mongolia. Multiple Oirat communities decided to stay near the Volga River region, not wanting to risk the dangerous trek back to Mongolia. This sect of people was given the name Kalmyk, by their Turkic neighbours. The name Kalmyk is derived from the Turkic word "Kalmak," which means "remnant" or "to remain." The origins of the word "Kalmyk" were either coined by Turkic peoples to refer to the Oirat Mongols who remained after the majority left in 1771 or to describe the sect of Oirats that, during their stay in southern Russia, did not convert to Islam, unlike many other Turkic and Mongol groups in the region. Supposedly, from the Turkic point of view, the Kalmyks were "those who remained pagan," resisting Islamic influence. Ultimately, the Kalmyks settled their dominance in the region and established

the culture and traditions that persisted into the modern-day.

That culture and tradition that was being systematically extinguished under Project Ulses. The operation was initiated on December 27th, 1943 by Mikhail Kalinin, Former Chairman of the Presidium of the Supreme Soviet of the USSR, and Alexander Gorkin, Former Secretary of the Presidium of the Supreme Council of the USSR, high-ranking Soviet officials, declaring the dissolution of the Kalmyk ASSR and the forced resettlement of its people. The wording of the document was as follows:

1. All Kalmyks living on the territory of the Kalmyk ASSR are to be resettled to other regions of the USSR, and the Kalmyk ASSR is to be liquidated.

The Council of People's Commissars of the USSR shall allocate land to Kalmyks in new settlement areas and provide them with the necessary state assistance for economic arrangements.

2. To form the Astrakhan Region within the RSFSR with its center in the city of Astrakhan.

To include in the Astrakhan region the districts of the former Kalmyk ASSR Dolbansky, Ketchenerovskiy, Lagansky, Privolzhsky, Troitsky, Ulan-Kholsky, Chernozem Sky and Justin Sky and the city of Elista; the districts of the Astrakhan Okrug Vladimirov Sky, Volodarsky, Yenataevsky, Ikryaninsky, Kamyzyaksky, Krasnoyarsk, Narimanov Sky, Kharabalinsky and the city of Astrakhan. The Astrakhan district of the Stalingrad region is to be liquidated.

3. The districts of the former Kalmyk ASSR Malo-Derbetovskiy and Sarpinsky shall be included in the Stalingrad region; Zapadny (Bashanta), Yashaltinsky shall be included in the Rostov region; Priyutinsky shall be included in the Stavropol region

The first step of the plan was to deport the Kalmyks living in Elista, the capital of the Kalmyk ASSR, via the Divnoje Railway station. The plan involved using lorries to transport the Kalmyks from Elista to the station, where they would be crammed into train cars. Transportation required 71 cars, "Studebeckers" that had been sold to the USSR by the United States. Soviet officials gave the all-clear to the Soviet 3rd Infantry Regiment to orchestrate the deportation of the Kalmyk people. On December 28, 1943 the regiment received the order to set up registration booths in "Elista-Astrakhan, Elista-Rostov, Elista-Stalingrad and Elista-Stavropol." That night the raids began. The following descriptions derive from interviews with survivors of the deportation. Soldiers, armed and unyielding, pounded on doors, giving families little time to react. Parents scrambled to dress their children against the biting winter cold, their hands trembling with fear and urgency.

Fathers grabbed what few possessions they could, blankets, bread, family photographs, while mothers clutched their children tightly. Entire villages were emptied, their residents herded into the town square under armed guard. The soldiers, indifferent to the anguish around them, shouted names and marked them off on their lists making sure everyone was accounted for with mechanical precision. The sound of pens striking clipboards mixed with the sobs of children and the muted despair of their elders. From the town square, the Kalmyks were loaded into train cars like cargo. Conditions were inhumane; the cars were overcrowded and poorly ventilated, offering little protection from the freezing temperatures. The journey to Siberia and Central Asia lasted weeks, during which many deportees succumbed to hunger, cold, and disease.

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By early 1944, most of the Kalmyk population had been transported to Siberia. This forced migration claimed thousands of lives, a tragic precursor to the hardships the survivors would face in exile. Entire families were shattered, and the cultural and linguistic fabric of the Kalmyk people was on the brink of irreparable damage. Estimates suggest that over one third of the Kalmyk population perished during this dark period. Once all civilians were relocated, the USSR searched through its own military, sending all active Kalmyk military personnel to relocate to Elista, to be stripped of their position and sent along with their fellow countrymen to the ends of Siberia. The Kalmyk story doesn't end at the deportation, however. Following this traumatic chapter, Kalmyks immigrated to various countries, forming a strong global diaspora. With the help of individuals and international organizations, they escaped the harsh memories of the Russian steppe and began rebuilding their community, working collectively to recuperate from hidden trauma and revive the forgotten Kalmyk culture. This deportation during Stalin's era reflects a deliberate Soviet strategy to target specific ethnic groups under the guise of political disloyalty, resulting in profound physiological and cultural consequences. Ultimately, the psychological consequences of the Kalmyk deportation extend beyond the initial event shaping patterns of identity loss and fragmented immigrant communities within the Kalmyk diaspora.

Reasons for Deportation

To understand the consequences of the Kalmyk deportation, one must first examine the Soviet government's motivations for orchestrating this mass displacement. At the heart of this tragedy lie three key factors that drove Stalin's campaign of genocide against the Kalmyk people.

Kalmyk Cavalry Corps

In the pre-World War II era, most people in the Kalmyk ASSR were pro-Communist, though many anti-Soviet and anti-Communist groups still existed in the ASSR. These groups gained strength when the Nazis occupied what is today western Kalmkyia. In their campaign to further encroach upon Soviet territory, the Nazis had overextended their supply lines, making them vulnerable to Soviet partisan attacks. In order to protect their supply chains, the Nazi army recruited the local Soviet populace into self-defense units. Tired from years of oppressive rule under an authoritarian Tsar and the subsequent ruling secularism of the Communist regime, the Kalmyks found common cause with the Nazis, viewing their alliance as a shared fight against tyranny. The Nazis successfully enlisted a small group of Kalmyk people, though the majority of Kalmyks battled for Soviet Russia. In September of 1942, the Nazi army recruited a cavalry unit in the Kalmyk ASSR, the Kalmyk Cavalry Corps (KCC), to help guard their supply lines and suppress Soviet partisan activities. The KCC actively participated in the Nazi punitive expeditions against the Kalmyk people in which the KCC contributed to the execution of “close to 20,000 people from the Kalmyk ASSR.” All KCC members were volunteers, including deserters from the Red Army or emigres from the Soviet state, as the Nazis eschewed forced recruitment. By July 1944, the Kalmyk Cavalry Corps had 3,458 horsemen. On paper, the actions of fewer than 5,000 Kalmyks in the KCC was the biggest reason why the Stalinist regime deported over 90,000 Kalymks to Siberia. However, in the first seven months of World War II, more than 20,000 Kalmyk soldiers fought bravely and fiercely on the frontlines on behalf of the Soviets against their Nazi invaders; in fact, “eight Kalmyks [received] awards as Heroes of the Soviet Union for their valor in combat against the Germans,” emphasizing the significant role the Kalymks played on the battlefield. Even after the Nazi invasion, the Kalymk people “collected 7,830,000 rubles to construct a tank battalion named “Soviet Kalmyk” as a gift to the Red Army,” a continued manifestation of their loyalty to the Soviets. Even Red Army soldiers were not safe, as Kalmyk-identifying soldiers and communists were still deported to Siberia. Despite the allegiance of most Kalmyk people to the Red Army, Stalin instead underscored the betrayal of the KCC, using it to rationalize the Kalmyk deportation.

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Inclusion of Ethnic Origin in Soviet Passports

The second factor lies in Stalin’s policy of mandating the inclusion of ethnic origin on Soviet passports, a move that allowed for the institutionalization of ethnic segregation

and further marginalized minorities. Before the 1930s, Soviet policies deliberately framed the primary conflict in society as a struggle between class enemies. It was a way for the state to pin the blame on the upper class rather than accepting their own failures. However, by the end of the 1930s, class had become less of a contentious subject, as “the class war associated with the revolution had now been won” with the death of the Tsar, and “it was no longer so important to identify ‘class enemies.’” The main contention of class in Soviet society was replaced by nationality, otherwise known as ethnic origin. A Soviet citizen could be easily identified as a minority by checking his or her passport. Individuals without a passport faced significant restrictions, as the 1930s saw the “introduction of mandatory urban registration” in major Soviet cities. If a child had one Russian and one Jewish parent, they often chose Russian for their passport ethnicity because “it was plainly the safest option,” highlighting that being a minority in the Soviet Union was worse than being a Russian. Relatives and passport clerks are even cited as saying, “Just write Russian[,] [i]t will be easier,” reflecting Stalin’s racist policies and efforts to erase ethnic diversity from the Soviet Union. During Stalin’s regime, individuals’ ethnicities, as recorded in their passports, became tools for their own systemic oppression, leading to targeted deportations and purges. Being labeled as specific ethnicities became problematic for citizens, including those identifying as Chechen during their forced relocation to Central Asia under Operation Chechevitsa. Similarly, the Crimean Tatars faced mass deportations in 1944, with their ethnicity-labeled passports facilitated their identification and removal. During Stalin’s anti-cosmopolitan campaign in the late 1940s and early 1950s, Jewish individuals were persecuted, with their passports effectively marking them for discrimination. These policies exemplify how Stalin utilized passport ethnicity classifications to systemically segregate and deport groups he deemed undesirable, weaponizing national documentation to enforce ethnic cleansing.

Soviet Secularism

The third main reason for the Kalymk deportation was the Soviet ideology behind atheism. During the 1960s, Soviet society was teeming with secularism, and ideologies that were not Marxist were shunned. Therefore, most Soviets authorities rejected reliance on religious ideologies, believing instead that true creative freedom could only be achieved through their own efforts. The Bolsheviks first developed their anti-religious ideals through a man named Ludwig Feuerbach. Feuerbach “advocated atheism,” and in 1841, published “The Essence of Christianity” a book critiquing Christianity and further-

ing his anti-religious ideals. In his book, Feuerbach “attempted to demonstrate that where- as men thought that they were worshipping God, they were, in fact, worshipping their own humanity,” accentuating his opposition towards religion. Feuerbach laid the foundation for the “de-sacralization of religion” on which Karl Marx created his own set of agnostic ideologies. Marx reinterpreted from Feuerbach’s teachings that “the true God was indeed Man” and how “it was mankind that should be worshiped”. The hostility Stalin and other Bolsheviks had towards religion derives from these thoughts. Churches were condemned as idealist, and their followers were also denounced due to following idealist principles that counteracted Marxist materialism. Since Buddhism is the dominant religion within the Kalmyk population, this forced elimination of the Kalmyk religion ostracized and angered many Buddhist Kalymks. Despite their historically nomadic lifestyle, Kalmyks still established stationary monasteries (khuruls) and functional mobile temples (kibitka khuruls). The Kalmyks’ deep association of their faith with their identity made them a target for Stalinsit purges and mass deportations. Stalin’s policies not only uprooted the Kalmyks physically but sought to sever their connection to Buddhism. In 1917 the Kalmyk ASSR had “105 monasteries ...with 5,270 residents,” and every single one was destroyed before 1941. Lamrimlin Khurul in Tsagan Aman, the first stationery Kalmyk Buddhist Temple, was deconstructed and repurposed for its raw materials symbolizing Soviet efforts to strip away religion in its territories. Religion, as the cornerstone of Kalmyk identity and a pillar of their community, was forcibly stripped away, leaving profound psychological scars on the people as we will see in the next section.

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Psychological trauma

In the immediate aftermath of the deportation during the 1940s and 1950s, survivors were subjected to forced labor and cultural isolation. The violent uprooting from their native land, the conditions of the overcrowded train cars, freezing temperatures, and lack of food created an environment conducive to despair and trauma. Research into similar experiences of other deported populations, such as Russian Koreans, has shown that the psychological consequences of such situations extend far beyond the circle of immediate survivors. Survivors’ children internalize unresolved trauma passed on from their parents causing higher levels of stress, a lesser self-identification, and difficulties in trusting others. In trauma studies this phenomenon is called transgenerational trauma. Oral histories with survivors have shown that many went silent about what they had endured, driven by fear of further persecution and cultural norms around silence, emotions and customs com-

monly experienced by victims of state violence. We know from the literature on Russian Koreans who had also been deported by Stalin that they imposed strict cultural norms emphasizing ‘keeping silence’ about past traumas, illustrating how repression leads to intergenerational silence and the suppression of painful memories. This silence often leaves subsequent generations with fragmented memories and unspoken pain in piecing together their family history. The Bowen Family Systems Theory (BFST), developed by American physicist Murray Bowen, argues that trauma and emotional patterns are transmitted across generations, shaping family dynamics and individual well-being. The Kalmyk experience exemplifies this, as the forced deportation and subsequent hardships left psychological scars that persisted long after resettlement. The suppression of trauma, rather than its acknowledgment, contributed to a cycle of inherited suffering. Tsagana Abbyaeva, a former deported Kalmyk born in 1932, reflects on how she avoided discussing her traumatic past with her family. Her daughter, Saglara Badushov, speaking on her behalf, born 1969, recalls that her mother “didn’t talk much about the deportation and kept a lot inside.” When asked whether she believed she had inherited trauma, she answered with a resounding: “yes.” This silence created a void where pain festered, forcing children to piece together fragmented histories while unconsciously absorbing the weight of unspoken suffering. Without a clear narrative, trauma was internalized rather than processed, reinforcing a cycle in which later generations carried the emotional burden of events they never personally experienced. In an interview with By’in Badushov, daughter of Saglara Badushov and granddaughter of Tsagana Abbyaeva born 2000, she reflects on the experience of her grandmother and says “I feel like [my grandmother’s] trauma was passed down to [my mother] and then to me, not just through stories, but through actions and expressions of emotion.” Had there been open discussions about the deportations, the grief, and the struggles of rebuilding, By’in remarks that “I might have been free of the unconscious unexamined burden.” This highlights the paradox of trauma within displaced communities: the instinct to suppress suffering for survival can, in the long run, deepen its psychological grip.

State vs. Personal Narratives

The Soviet government’s stigma against the Kalmyk people, branding them as traitors and inferiors, deepened their isolation and intensified the psychological burden on younger generations. Research among Russian Koreans, for example, has shown that transgenerational trauma is often reflected in problems concerning one’s own identity. Irina Fan in her research among Russian Koreans, says “[The] children’s parents perceived

the deportation through the prism of Soviet propaganda[;] Neither their encounter with repression and deportation ... brought these Koreans...to a truthful assessment of the actions of the authorities.” While the Soviet version of history, shaped by propaganda, was readily accessible through the state, it concealed the true extent of past atrocities. Only by contrasting this imposed narrative with inherited cultural memory could Korean individuals uncover the truth about their past, and, in turn, shape their future. Similarly, in the case of the Kalmyks, the state not only downplayed their trauma but also directly facilitated the erasure of Kalmyk identity. In Siberia, many Kalmyk children could not prove to their peers that a people called the Kalmyks existed. The Kalmyks became invisible. The children born to Kalmyk parents after the deportation were not entitled to birth certificates, meaning that travel between countries, job applications, and movement into many cities became impossible for the Kalmyk people. The destruction of the Kalmyk identity through state policy was further reinforced by propaganda. State institutions controlled collective memory by manipulating archives, altering historical curricula for young people, and promoting narratives that framed history solely through the lens of the Soviet people’s collective struggle. Elza Guchinova, in *The Politics of History in Russia and Theatricalisation of Traumatic Events*, argues that if the Kalmyk people present a “softer” version of their deportation, one that emphasizes friendship with Siberians, then younger generations will perceive late Stalinism in a way that align with the state’s interests. These revised versions of history, crafted to serve Soviet political aims, were disseminated across the country. They propagated the false idea that the deportation of the Kalmyks was a necessary evil, one that, despite its hardships, was part of a broader suffering shared by all Soviet citizens. Such a memory policy suppresses the cultural and historical identity of the Kalmyk people, as their core collective memory becomes overshadowed by the fabricated trauma of the entire Soviet people. This created a cultural alienation and self-doubt especially among younger Kalmyks, unable to understand how to meld this state narrative with family histories.

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Beyond that, works by theorist Ron Eyerman explain the role of collective memory in shaping one’s identity. In Ron Eyerman’s *Cultural Trauma Slavery and the Formation of the African American Identity*, he clarifies how slave terms such as “former slave” or “daughter of slaves” became a collective memory uniting all African Americans in the United States. The self-imposed categorization was meant to “counter, those of the dominant white society” known as “a counter memory.” Similarly the efforts of the Kalmyk diaspora to document and share experiences create a counter-narrative to the official Sovi-

et one. Books like “The Man is Wealthy by his Relatives; He is like a Mighty Tree,” which documents the history of a Kalmyk family, showing the Kalmyk people’s efforts to challenge and resist the dominant Soviet narrative. Not only does such a process preserve their cultural identity, but it also serves as a kind of psychological catharsis for descendants. In an article review of *Shadows of Trauma: Memory and the Politics of Postwar Identity* by Aleida Assmann, Susanne S. Cammack explains Assmann’s theory on how state versus individual memory offers insight on how people cope with the conflicting narratives. Assmann contrasts political and cultural memory, whereas “political memory relies on historical information to create a unified and instrumental collective identity, cultural memory resists such reductionism” For the Kalmyks, this distinction played out in a way the Soviet regime controlled narratives about their deportation and suffering. Political memory, enforced through propaganda, education, and censorship, framed the deportation as a necessary hardship for the greater Soviet good, minimizing the ethnic persecution at its core. This not only dismissed the trauma of the Kalmyks but also forced survivors into silence, as any acknowledgment of their unique suffering risked being labeled as anti-Soviet. In contrast, cultural memory among the Kalmyks persisted through oral and personal testimonies to preserve their traditions and language. However, because the state actively suppressed these alternative narratives, Kalmyks struggled to find communal validation for their experiences. Their history became fractured, official records denied their suffering, while personal and communal memories told a different, painful truth. This further isolated survivors and made collective healing difficult, as the very act of remembering the truth became an act of resistance.

Loss of Kalmyk Identity

Soviet propaganda also contributed to a Kalmyk cultural amnesia which disregarded or minimized the importance of the atrocity. Elza Guchinova, in her work *Visible and Invisible Identity*, talks about how the destruction of the Kalmyk native language and religiosity impacted Kalmyk identity. She draws the conclusion that “religion is the opium of the people and by a tendency to domination by the Russian language among ethnic minorities as the language of state power.” The Soviet suppression of the Kalmyk language in favor of Russian and the dismantling of Kalmyk Buddhism in favor of Soviet secularism are stark examples of the Kalmyks’ inherited cultural memory versus the sanitized, bureaucratic narrative presented by the Soviet state. During the deportation, the Soviets propelled a cultural fog that emerged between the older generation, born before the Russian Revolu-

tion and who did not speak Russian, and their grandchildren, born before the deportation but fluent in both Russian and Kalmyk. Additionally, the next generation born in Siberia to survivors experienced a profound generational divide. Many of the younger generation thought it was shameful to speak or to be Kalmyk; they refused to learn or could not learn the language. This was exemplified by Stalin's policy of Russinisation, or *sblizhenie*, which aimed to assimilate Soviet youth by indoctrinating them with Russian culture, language, and beliefs, forcing them into a collective Soviet identity. In Siberia, where survival took precedence over cultural preservation, the state's relentless promotion of Russian chauvinism made it easier for many Kalmyks to abandon their heritage in favor of adopting a Russian identity. Even Kalmyk adults deliberately did not speak their native language to fellow Kalmyks for fear of being marginalized. With deteriorating social conditions, starting with the language, the Kalmyk identity began slowly fading. This sort of forced erasure further exacerbated the psychological burden on the Kalmyks because, beyond just trauma, their pain was invalidated and excluded from national discourse. Tsagana Abbyaeva continues on her experience that people who "attempted to voice their experiences were often met with hostility"; thus, suppressing their pain rather than seeking consensus and support. The state's propaganda extended to reshaping the identity of the deported Kalmyks by systematically destroying their cultural symbols such as Buddhist temples, not only a physical act, but also a psychological one, obliterating a tangible connection to Kalmyk heritage. Monks had renounced their vows and decided to blend into the population, parents only conducted Buddhist practices in the privacy of their homes, and the next generation of Kalmyk children were deciding not to partake in "remnants of the past" in reference to religion. The exiled Kalmyks were under pressure to be assimilated into Soviet society, to adopt the Russian language and customs while suppressing their own traditions. Propaganda created a generational gap within the Kalmyk community. Therein lies another source of psychological distress—the tension between imposed state identity and familial memory, as individuals struggle with questions of belonging and self-perception.

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Immigration and Integration Struggles

Where generations of deported Kalmyks were having questions of belonging, different Kalmyk diasporas in Europe, the Americas, and western Germany felt the same effect. The first significant wave of Kalmyk emigration began during the Russian Civil War (1917-1922). Many Kalmyks fought alongside the White Army and fled the advancing Bolshevik forces; nations like Yugoslavia, Czechoslovakia, and France Became flooded

with Kalmyk emigres. During World War II, as Nazi forces retreated westward, a second wave of migration followed, consisting of tens of thousands of displaced people, including German civilians and Kalmyks. Many Kalmyks were forced into this migration or joined voluntarily to escape Soviet oppression. After the war, these displaced Kalmyks faced new challenges in postwar Europe. Following the Third Reich's surrender, the Yalta Conference agreements led to widespread forced Soviet repatriation, where approximately 5.2 million displaced persons, including 90% of the Kalmyks living in Europe, returned to the Soviet Union. The Soviets sought repatriation for ideological and practical means: they needed to repopulate their empty workforce with an entire generation lost in the war and punish Nazi collaborators and Soviet traitors. For many Kalmyks, return meant imprisonment or Siberian deportation, the equivalent of death. Returning to the Soviet Union meant facing the punishment of Stalin's regime, while remaining in Europe brought its own form of trauma, living as displaced individuals in unfamiliar nations, surrounded by alien cultures and people.

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Around 1.2 million people who resisted repatriation found themselves in displaced persons (DP) camps in Western Germany, particularly in the American zone. For those Kalmyks who successfully avoided repatriation, the DP camps in Germany were both a refuge and a site of continued struggle. An organization was established to address the DP crisis by facilitating their resettlement in Western nations. The International Refugee Organization (IRO) worked alongside Kalmyk community leaders in the DP camps and elsewhere in Europe spending years fighting for a way out of the camps. Badma Oulanoff, dubbed the intellectual leader of the Kalmyk diaspora and who had survived the invasion of Northern France after fleeing Czechoslovakia, Sancha Stepanow, a Russian-born lawyer who had been in Prague during the German invasion and ended up in the Ingolstadt DP camp after the war, along with a number of others, founded the Kalmook National Representation in Europe with the goal of lobbying western powers, emphasizing the Kalmyks' anti-Communist stance and their foreseeable contributions as industrious settlers. Kalmyks and Kalmyk supporters across the globe, convinced the International Refugee Organization to ramp up its efforts to find a nation to admit them. From Canada to Morocco to Pakistan, Kalmyks were rejected entry by over two dozen nations. Former DP Kalmyk, Erinsin Badushov recalls, when he was about four years old, he and his family were ready to "go to Paraguay, [since his] luggage was already stamped for Paraguay." Kalmyk's envisioning lives in the United States were also met with grim news. Due to prevailing Asian exclusion laws, Kalmyks were classified as Asian under US immigration law and therefore

denied entry. However, in July of 1951, Attorney general J. Howard McGrath, out of a sense that admitting them would reflect favorably on the US's image during the heat of the Cold War, declared Kalmyks to be racially Asian but legally Caucasian in a Bureau of Immigration Appeals test case argued by the IRO. While not foregoing discrimination, this decision allowed legal free access to Kalmyks to pass through to the United States, making them the only racially colored group to be admitted under a law limited to European refugees. Their access to the United States was one of the last precedent cases for the revocation of Asian exclusion laws under the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1952. In preparation for their journey, the IRO transferred the first large contingent of Kalmyks to multiple locations then onto USS General RM Blatchford. The former naval vessel was to transport the DPs to the United States, however, on the day of departure, John J. McCloy, US High Commissioner for Occupied Germany, directed by the US State Department, ordered all Kalmyks removed from the ship. This came to a drastic shock to Kalmyks and the IRO which their refugee camps were set to close in the coming weeks. Due to the Kalmyks' stateless predicament, the IRO and American non-governmental organizations urged the U.S. State Department to reverse the order. After three grueling days, the decision was overturned so swiftly that it did not delay the migration of any Kalmyks seeking entry into the United States. However, the origin of the order, seemingly at odds with U.S. interests, traced back to a sponsoring organization in the Brethren Service Commission. The Brethren Service, believing it was in their best interest, chose to sponsor the Kalmyks' journey to bring national attention to their plight and demonstrate their commitment to racial and religious acceptance. Although they had multiple resettlement options available, they temporarily halted the Kalmyks' arrival for one key reason: they needed more time to secure their preferred settlement location in New Mexico. Although it was not the preferred resettlement choice for either the Brethren Service or the Kalmyk people, it was favored by the United States Displaced Persons Commission, the agency overseeing the DP program and organization the Brethren Service called on for assistance. The Commission was supported in their endeavors by the United States Employment Service, the Department of Agriculture, and the Department of Labor's Farm Placement Service. Erinsin Badushov remembers being shipped to "New Mexico" because the United States and its agencies "thought us Kalmyks were farmers and could help farm." Against the wishes of the Kalmyk people and at great inconvenience to them, the Brethren Service halted the Kalmyk migration for three days and rerouted them to New Mexico. In doing so, it demonstrated loyalty not to the displaced people but to the organizations that influenced its decisions.

Although many Kalmyks eventually resettled on the East Coast, particularly in New Jersey and Philadelphia, the absence of records in the U.S. State Department and the Displaced Persons Commission highlights the indifference and disregard the United States and its agencies had for displaced and struggling communities.

Integration

Despite finding new homes, Kalmyk emigres continued to grapple with the psychological and cultural impact of displacement. The uncertainty of not knowing if you will be allowed to enter a safe country. The forced separation from Siberian Kalmyks, as DP camp residents didn't suffer the same hardships as Siberian Kalmyks. Erinsin Badushov, born August 1948, Berlin in an American displaced person camp, recounts his memory of "going and getting milk for [his] family" and having a "tricycle" but besides that "not too much." While a former Siberian Kalmyk Tsagana Abbyaeva, born 1932, Kalmykia, recalls her memory of the deportation. When she was only eleven years old, the NKVD broke down the door informing her and her family they had "24 hours to leave their homes and were instructed not to take anything with them." People who did not cooperate "were killed on the spot." On the way to Siberia they were transported by cattle cars and kids and adults were dying daily. She remembers that "most of [the Kalmyks] got sick on the train, and only a third of the population made it to the final destination" When arriving in Siberia, the people already living there thought the Kalymks were "barbarians" and treated them like "slaves." Treated like an animal, Tsagana had to stay in a barn to shelter from the cold while working for the leftovers of the locals. Due to the vastly different experiences of the two Kalmyk groups, tensions emerged within the once tightly knit community as increasing numbers of Siberian and DP camp Kalmyks arrived in the United States. The sense of collective trauma and identity that the two groups had in their own environments was now lost in a sea of new information. However, in America, the challenges of assimilation overwhelmed the feelings of difference between Kalmyks. Despite the challenges of resettlement in New Mexico and the hardships of being immigrants in pre-civil rights America, the Kalmyks set aside their historical differences and moved forward together. Small Kalmyk diasporas settled in New Jersey and Pennsylvania, drawn by affordable housing and work opportunities in construction. However, these opportunities were not without significant challenges. Kalmyks, already grappling with the diminishing prevalence of their language within their own community, now had to learn English and adapt to unfamiliar societal norms. They faced prejudice as an Asian minority, despite being legally classified

as Caucasian, forcing them to navigate a complex web of cultural and racial dynamics in their new environment. Buddhist temples became vital centers for spiritual and cultural preservation. For example, the establishment of the first Kalmyk Buddhist temple in Howell, New Jersey, Rashi Gempil Ling, provided a place not only for worship but provided a haven where Kalmykse transmitted traditions to younger generations. Social gatherings, language schools, and holidays reinforced a sense of unity, helping the diaspora lift up from the fleeting identity they faced in the Soviet Union and build it back stronger.

Conclusion

The Kalmyk deportation and diaspora serve as a grim reminder of the consequences of state violence and the strength of displaced communities. It is a story not unique to the Kalmyk people, but reflects broader patterns of systemic oppression in global history. The Kalmyk story explains how state policies of cultural erasure and discrimination can reverberate throughout generations. Similar patterns of scapegoating and forced resettlement still haunt marginalized populations today, thus the Kalmyk experience is a cautionary tale about the consequences of unchecked state power. Ultimately, the psychological consequences of the deportation are still felt in modern-day communities, with patterns of identity loss and fragmentation, however, with the knowledge of the past there can be hope for a better future.

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WHICH THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK BEST EXPLAINS DEMOCRATIC DEVELOPMENT OR LACK THEREOF IN THE SYRIAN ARAB REPUBLIC?

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Over the course of eleven days in December 2024, the reconstructed Islamist insurgent group Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) unseated the Ba'ath Party, which had ruled Syria as a one-party state since 1963, through a lightning offensive. Rebel strategic victory, however, is, historically, an abnormal route for regime change in Syria. Indeed, between the country's independence and the Ba'ath takeover, politically active generals have internally overthrown the incumbent government in Damascus ten times in successful coups. As such, Syria has remained predominantly autocratic since its conceptual inauguration as a nation-state. A structuralist analysis of Syria's modern political history reveals the disproportionate institutional power of the military as a historical roadblock to democracy in Syria. The new HTS-led government must confront this time-honored barrier in order to stabilize Syria and usher in democracy.

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The modern history of Syria began in 1916 with the Sykes-Picot Agreement, a backroom deal between Britain and France that promised each power a sphere of influence in the Fertile Crescent. The Ottoman Empire, a loser in the First World War, was formally dismembered at the 1919-1920 Paris Peace Conference, and France won the charge of shepherding the "Mandate for Syria and the Lebanon," whose people the newly-inaugurated League of Nations deemed "not yet able to stand by themselves under the strenuous conditions of the modern world." Throughout the interwar period, French authorities established five states within this mandate territory, cordoning one off for the now-Lebanese and with the remaining four, creating a jurisdiction with roughly the present-day borders of Syria, although some small portions of the mandate are now recognized by the United Nations as belonging to Türkiye or Israel. This precursor entity to the Syrian Arab Republic, known eventually as the Mandatory Syrian Republic, founded

many of the institutions inherited by later Syrian rulers.

Most criticisms of France and Britain's conduct in the era following Sykes-Picot focus on their arbitrary drawing of borders without regard for ethno-religious distribution and, more accurately, their hasty imposition of the Western-style nation-state model on peoples who had only ever lived under a multiethnic empire. While a valid ground for the denunciation of colonialism, this explanation for internal conflict does not wholly bring to light Syria's authoritarian streak. Indeed, although geographer Ieuan Griffiths cites Ghana and Benin as particularly egregious examples of sloppy postcolonial border-drawing, neither has had a large-scale war fought within its boundaries, and both score an order of magnitude higher on democracy indices than Syria. As such, this paper recounts the obstruction to the development of Syrian democracy by the outsized power of the military entrenched since the French mandate period.

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For the first half-decade of the mandate, colonial authorities mostly restrained the formation of a majority-Syrian fighting force, for fear of creating an independent, anti-French base of power. However, following the Great Syrian Revolt of 1925, France reversed its unsuccessful anti-insurgent policy and began to use mostly Syrian troops to staff the territory's defense units. These *Troupes spéciales du Levant* drew predominantly from the Ottoman-era officer corps, and the French senior commanders deliberately elevated members of minority nationalities within Syria—namely, the Druze and Alawites—to more high-ranking positions than the country's Sunni majority. This strategy functioned to set the interests of the professional military class opposed to majoritarian populism, and by 1927, native Syrian troops accounted for 35% of the colony's fighting force. After a failed bid for independence in 1936, Syria fell under the control of the Nazi-aligned Vichy government in France during the early years of World War II, but British troops tossed out the Axis forces from the mandate by July 1941. For the remainder of the war, "Free France" under Charles de Gaulle focused their attention in Syria on cracking down against pro-independence factions. When revolutionary fighting broke out in 1945, France bombarded Damascus and attempted to detain Syria's elected provisional government, but pressure from the British led to Paris's eventual recognition of Shukri al-Quwatli's leadership of an independent Syria in 1946.

Quwatli opposed both the Trans-Arabian petroleum pipeline and the creation of Israel, drawing the ire of Western states. In March of 1949, per former president of Aleppo College Alford Carleton, Colonel Husni al-Zaim leaned on "the French military tradition" to stage a coup against Quwatli, giving the armed forces of government. Assis-

tance to Zaim from the CIA has been alleged but never confirmed. Power changed hands between military commanders until 1954, when elections were restored following mass protests. In 1958, Syrian Army Chief of Staff Afif al-Bizri exploited US-Turkish threats of intervention to pressure the government into forming a political union with Colonel Nasser's military regime in Egypt. The army's radicalized officer corps, frustrated with old-school Nasserism, pushed through two successive coups in 1961 and 1963, eventually bringing the Ba'ath Party, a vanguard of the "new Arab nationalism" to power. Scholar of comparative politics Amos Perlmutter explains the party's ability to preach a brand of "socialism" from a traditionally reactionary institution by citing the armed force's relative monopoly on social mobility. Throughout the upheaval of the 1950s and 1960s, Syria remained mostly as it was under Ottoman rule: parochial, decentralized, and rural; poor Syrians best chance at climbing the social ladder manifested through the military. Moreover, the military academies at Homs and Hama were early breeding grounds for a degree of interethnic unity against common enemies, namely Israel. This apparent unity, although outpacing the division of the Ottoman and French eras, skewed in favor of the traditional hierarchy of the officer corps.

When Alawite General Hafez al-Assad consolidated power in 1970, he continued the inordinate promotion of Alawite officers to senior positions and developed a system of political patronage for preferred sects and tribes that his son Bashar would continue until 2024. Essentially, the military accrued such disproportionate political sway in Syria because of two opposite but intersecting trends: firstly, the weakness of civil institutions such that the armed forces became the public's only option for redress of grievances and personal advancement; and secondly, the calcification of an elite military bureaucracy whose minority-dominant composition discouraged friendliness to democracy in the barracks. Bashar al-Assad, however, grew too conscientious of his country's history of successful military putsches. He reduced training for soldiers, intensely surveilled the army rank-and-file, and restricted communication among generals in an attempt to "coup-proof" his reign. While this strategy seemingly succeeded in stymying coups, it left the army defenseless when HTS undertook its December 2024 offensive, which forced Assad to flee to Moscow.

Ahmed al-Sharaa, Syria's transitional Prime Minister since January 2025, has promised to work towards "a republic with a parliament and an executive government" but has warned that elections may not come until 2030. Sharaa did not govern democratically in Idlib province, which HTS controlled starting in 2020. Still, his interim govern-

ment has overseen an uptick in religious freedom and civil liberties, keeping the hope for Syria's eventual democratization alive. French journalist Wassim Nasr, who has met with Sharaa twice, believes that the new government will prioritize the restoration of standardization and meritocracy in the military. Even so, without the relative strengthening of the economy and civil institutions, the armed forces will remain unduly influential. Thus, the interim government's ability to offer social mobility and some amount of representation through non-military bureaucracy will hold a crucible to preventing another coup before elections come, if they ever do, in the Syrian Arab Republic.

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